

Govt extends slum rehabilitation eligibility cut-off to Jan 1, 2025

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Tuesday approved rehabilitation benefits for all eligible families living in settlements established till January 1, 2025, in a decision expected to benefit nearly 20 lakh people and facilitate permanent housing for an estimated 4-5 lakh families. Eligible families will be provided multi-storey flats equipped with all essential civic amenities.

The decision was taken at the 36th board meeting of the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB), chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the Delhi

Secretariat, according to a statement released here. Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma and senior officials attended the meeting. The decision is in line with the outcomes of a recent high-level review meeting chaired by Union Minister for Home Affairs and Cooperation Amit Shah and the provisions of the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy 2026.

The move removes a key hurdle that had prevented many families from qualifying for rehabilitation benefits under earlier eligibility norms and expands the scope of the recently approved Delhi Slum

and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2026, the statement said.

"Nearly 20 lakh people living in Delhi's JJ clusters stand to benefit after the city government decided to extend rehabilitation benefits to all eligible slum-dwelling families settled till January 1, 2025, paving the way for permanent housing for an estimated 4-5 lakh families," the chief minister said.

She said the decision would provide a pathway to permanent and dignified housing for lakhs of families living in JJ clusters across the national capital and strengthen the Government's commitment to "Jahan



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, State Minister Ashish Sood, and others, during a meeting on the Relocation Policy 2026 in New Delhi

Jhuggi, Wahan Makaan". The chief minister further said the revised cut-off date would enable a much larger

number of eligible families to avail rehabilitation benefits and secure permanent housing.

According to the chief minister, eligible beneficiaries would be provided multi-storey flats equipped with essential civic amenities. As far as possible, rehabilitation would be undertaken within or near existing settlements to minimise disruption to livelihoods and social networks, she added.

The chief minister said the initiative was aimed not only at providing houses but also at improving the overall quality of life of residents through planned rehabilitation colonies with adequate social infrastructure.

The proposed colonies will include facilities such as schools, anganwadi centres,

health centres, children's playgrounds and other basic public amenities required for community living, she said.

The decision is in line with the outcomes of a recent high-level review meeting chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah and provisions of the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2026, the statement said.

The chief minister also said the government is considering provisions to address family expansion in slum clusters. In cases where members of the same family are living in separate units on different floors of a structure, they may be brought

within the ambit of rehabilitation, subject to prescribed conditions and payment of additional charges.

It wasn't immediately clear, however, what special provision would be made in such cases. The rehabilitation programme would be implemented in mission mode through coordinated efforts of the Centre and the Delhi government, according to the chief minister.

The statement also said the decision is expected to bring a large number of slum residents into the formal housing network and provide them with access to better living conditions and civic services.

LG Sandhu reviews Zero Waste Colony in Navjeevan Vihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday reviewed "Zero Waste Colony" in Navjeevan Vihar in the city, saying it demonstrates how collective civic responsibility can contribute to a more sustainable urban environment.



According to the statement, the LG described the zero-waste model as "one of the best practices in Delhi", while calling for its replication across the city, particularly in unauthorised and low-income group (LIG) colonies. Over 10 lakh kilograms of waste successfully diverted from Delhi's landfills by the Navjeevan Vihar colony over the last eight years. During the visit, Sandhu inspected the colony's Reduce-Reuse-Recycle (RRR) Centre, decentralised aerobic composting units, source-segregation mechanisms and rain-water harvesting system, the statement read.

The LG commended the community-led initiative and said it demonstrated how collective civic responsibility could contribute to a cleaner and more sustainable urban environment, it further read.

Highlighting the need to expand such initiatives, the LG directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to encourage Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) to adopt

similar self-sustaining models, the statement read.

"The LG also asked the civic body to explore funding mechanisms for replicating decentralised zero-waste and composting projects in less affluent colonies and to systematically tap Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) funds for creating infrastructure such as Aerobins and RRR centres," the statement read. Emphasising the need for behavioural change, the LG said, "Government agencies cannot achieve sustainable waste management without active public contribution and a deep sense of ownership among citizens."

According to the statement, he stressed the importance of collective action, saying, "The journey from waste to wealth begins at home."

Remarking that successful solutions were already emerging from within the city, the LG said, "There is no need to look to other cities or nations for solutions when such best practices are

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has ordered a corruption probe against two senior Delhi Health Department officers over alleged irregularities in the procurement of medicines and other medical supplies for Government hospitals.

Treating the allegations with "utmost seriousness", the chief minister has sought an inquiry under Section 17A of the Prevention of

Corruption Act, 1988, into complaints against Dr Vatsala Aggarwal and Deputy Controller of Accounts Neeraj Chopra linked to the procurement process, a senior Delhi government official said.

The Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) of the Delhi government has arrested a doctor in connection with a Rs 350-crore fraud case involving the procurement of medicines and medical equipment for Government hospitals in the national



Capital. The Delhi Government has suspended Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, Head

Director General of Health Services, after obtaining the approval of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

"In the latest move, the government has recommended an investigation into allegations against Dr Vatsala Aggarwal and Deputy Controller of Accounts Neeraj Chopra following complaints regarding the functioning of the Central Procurement Agency (CPA)," the official said.

Probe ordered against two health officials over medicine procurement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Construction work on the Central Secretariat Metro station, a key stop on the proposed Central Vista Metro corridor connecting RK Ashram Marg and Indraprastha under the extension of Delhi Metro's Magenta Line, will commence on Wednesday, officials said.

According to the official, the construction work will begin at Gate 3 of Central Secretariat Metro station in the presence of Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal.

The new station will form part of the RK Ashram Marg-Indraprastha corridor, an extension of the Magenta Line, aimed at improving metro connectivity to the redeveloped



Central Vista area and major government offices along the Kartavya Path.

Approved by the Centre in December last year, the 9.91 km corridor is expected to provide direct metro access to the Kartavya Bhawans and other administrative complexes in Central Delhi. The project is likely to benefit around 60,000 office-goers and nearly two lakh visitors daily by offering doorstep

NDMC bans road-cutting works during monsoon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has banned road-cutting works between July 1 and September 30 to ensure public safety and smooth traffic movement during the monsoon season.

The restriction has been imposed to prevent water-logging, road damage, traffic disruptions, and inconvenience to residents and commuters during the rainy months, an official statement said. Key directions issued by NDMC including, all ongoing road-cutting works must be properly completed, neatly levelled, dressed, and fully restored well before the onset of the monsoon season to ensure public safety and avoid



inconvenience to pedestrians and motorists.

The civic body said exceptions may be made for urgent public utility services or emergency works, subject to prior approval from the NDMC Chairperson.

"NDMC has directed that all ongoing road-cutting works be completed and roads restored properly before the onset of the monsoon to avoid inconvenience to pedestrians and motorists," the statement said.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of the President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work. Tender No.: 2581019TSDSSBR, Name of work: Provision for Supply and Installation of Modified Drain Pipe, Dustbin Panel, Air Duct Scoop and Anti-Condensation Insulation for Vande Bharat Coaches. Approximate cost: ₹ 90,51,383.68/- including GST, Earnest money: ₹ 1,81,100/-, Completion period of the work: 18 Months, Date and time for opening of tender: 10.07.2026 at 15:00, Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen: Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in w.e.f. 18.06.2026, 18:34 hrs. No.: 25.8,1019.TSD.SSB Date: 19.06.2026 2137/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SVAM SOFTWARE LIMITED

Registered Address: 224, G/F, Swayam Sewa, Co-Operative Housing Society Ltd., Jhilmil, Delhi-110032 • E-mail: svamsoftwareltd@gmail.com • Website: www.svamsoftwareltd.in Contact no: 011-35943509 • CIN: L65100DL1992PLC047327

NOTICE OF EXTRA-ORDINARY GENERAL MEETING AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

Notice is hereby given that the Extra Ordinary General Meeting (EGM) of the Members of the Company will be held on Tuesday, 14th July, 2026 at 03:00 P.M. through Video Conferencing (VC) / Other Audio Video Means (OAVM) to transact the special business as set out in the notice of EGM.

EGM will be held through VC/OAVM without physical presence of the Members and in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act") read with rules made thereunder and Circular No. 14/2020 dated April 08, 2020, Circular No. 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs followed by Circular No. 20/2020 dated May 05, 2020 and Circular No. 22/2020 dated January 13, 2021 and all other relevant circulars issued from time to time issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") and Circular dated May 12, 2020 issued by Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI Circular") to transact the business as set out in the Notice of the EGM. Members attending the EGM through VC/OAVM facility shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act.

In compliance with the above circulars, the EGM Notice has been electronically sent on Monday, 22nd June, 2026 to all the Members whose names appeared in the Register of Members / Register of Beneficial owners as on close of business hours on Friday, 12th June, 2026 and who have registered their email addresses with the Depository Participants or with the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Company ("R&T Agent") or with the Company. The Notice of the EGM is also available on the Company's website at www.svamsoftwareltd.in website of stock exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and on website of e-voting facility provider i.e. National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL") at www.evoting.nsdl.com.

Manner of updating e-mail address is as below:

Members holding shares in Dematerialized mode, who have not registered/updated their email addresses with their Depository Participants, are requested to register/update their email addresses with their respective Depository Participants with whom they maintain their Demat Account.

a) The Company has provided the facility to the Members to cast their vote on the matters set forth in EGM Notice, either by way of "remote e-voting" facility, prior to the EGM or by way of electronic voting system during the EGM. The instructions for joining the EGM and the manner of participation and voting are provided in the Notice of the EGM.

b) The manner of voting by the Members holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for members who have not registered their email address, facility for voting shall be exercised through electronic means at EGM.

c) A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the Cut-off date i.e. July 7th, 2026 only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting or participation at the EGM and voting through electronic voting system thereafter.

d) The remote e-voting will commence on Saturday, 11th July, 2026 at 9:00 A.M. (IST) on and be concluded on Monday, 13th July, 2026 at 5:00 P.M. (IST).

e) Any Person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes member of the Company after dispatch of notice of EGM and who holds Shares of the Company as of cut-off date i.e., 7th July, 2026, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in. However, if holder is already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting then the use of existing user ID and password for casting the vote shall work.

f) E-voting shall not be allowed beyond Monday, 13th July, 2026 at 5:00 P.M. (IST).

g) Further the facility for voting through electronic voting system will also be made available during the EGM, to the Members who are attending the EGM and have not already cast their votes(s) through remote e-voting.

h) Members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting may also attend the EGM, but shall not be allowed to vote again at the EGM.

i) If any Member wishes to get a printed copy of the EGM notice, the Company shall send the same, free of cost, upon receipt of request from the Member.

j) A person, whose name is recorded in the register of Members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting.

In case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-voting user manual for Shareholders available at the download section at www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on toll free no.: 1800 1020 990 and 1800 22 44 30 or send a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in.

Members are requested to carefully read all the Notes set out in the Notice of the EGM and in particular, instructions for joining the EGM, manner of casting vote through remote e-voting or through electronic voting system during the EGM.

By order of the Board
For, Svam Software Limited,
Place : Delhi
Date : 22nd June, 2026 Sd/- Harish Kumar Sharma • Managing Director - DIN: 10785775

LOST AND FOUND

It is informed to the general public that Tarun Seth S/o late V.K Seth, R/O --D22, The Belaire D Sector- 54, Gold Course Road, Gurugram-122002, Haryana has lost original 12th standard certificate issued by ISC board on 15.06.1999, for passing year 1999, bearing S.No. BC.1201667 and index number B/9596/095.

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all that my client, Mr. Ganiga Vishnu Sharma S/o Late Shri Ram Asra Shastri R/O 196, Arjun Nagar, Safdarjung Enclave, South West Delhi, Delhi, 110029, Allottee/ Mutatee/Purchaser of Property No. 196, Kharsa No.50/4, Arjun Nagar, Safdarjung Enclave, South West Delhi, Delhi-110029. The original documents i.e. Original Gift Deed, of the above said Flat/Plot/Property have been lost. An F.I.R./NCR/LR No.392068/2026, dated 23/06/2026, to this effect has been lodged in P.S.Crime Branch, Delhi. Any person (s) claiming any right, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write/contact with above named person at above Address/Phone 9711571444, within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property, can personally inform or write to Concerned Authority, New Delhi/NCR.

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Liza Borah, W/o No.14877231N Nk Biswajit Hazarika, R/o- Jalukonibarin, Gazpuria Gaon, PO- Titabor, Assam - 785630, declare that in my husband's service documents my D.O.B. is wrongly written as 17/04/1996 whereas my correct D.O.B. is 17/04/1993 which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1454)C I, Madhurima Mondal Chain, W/o No.14875073L Nk Surajit Chain, R/o- Vill- Gopalpur, PO- Bandhmura, PS- Katwa, Dist- Purba Bardhaman, West Bengal- 713150, have changed my name from Madhurima Mondal to Madhurima Mondal Chain, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public West Bengal.
PD(1455)C I, Khajani Devi, Mother of No.14849882N Hav/MT Rakesh Kumar, R/o- Vill- Gagharwas, PO- Suratpura, Teh- Rajgarh, Dist- Churu, Rajasthan- 331023, have changed my name from Khajani Devi to Khajani, vide affidavit dated 23/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1456)C I, Nitu Kumari, D/o JC- 471948P Ex-Sub Suresh Kumar, R/o- Vill/PO- Khinwasar, Teh- Gudha Goji, Dist- Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan- 333012 have changed my name from Nitu Kumari to Nittu Kumari, vide affidavit dated 23/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1457)C

I, Soni Singh, W/o No.16020376L L/Hav Satyendra Singh, R/o - Vill & PO- Rurwahar, Teh- Akbarpur, Dist- Kanpur Dehat, U.P., have changed my name from Soni Singh to Soni Devi, vide affidavit dated 23/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1450)C I, Reeta Devi, W/o No.16019766F Hav Jai Prakash Yadav, R/o- Lavkani, Gauri Bazar, Deoria, U.P.- 274202, declare that in my husband's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Rita Devi, whereas my correct name is Reeta Devi, which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1451)C I, Reshma Devi, Mother of No.16023316F L/Hav Dharmendra Singh, R/o- VPO- Digner, Teh- Sadar, Dist- Agra, U.P.- 283125, have changed my name from Reshma Devi to Reso Devi, vide affidavit dated 23/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1452)C I, No.15414268H Hav Sekar S, R/o- Vill- Kannigapuram, PO- Rathinagiri, Dist- Ranipet, Tamilnadu- 632517, declare that my Mother's name is wrongly written as Badmawathi in my service record whereas her correct name is Padmavathi Siva which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1453)C

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER:: PWD BUILDING::
ASSAM:: GUWAHATI-3.

No. নিবিদা প্রসংগ নং. CEB/MECH/16/2026/2

PRESS NOTICE

নিবিদা আহ্বান করা জাননী

The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites bids from eligible contractors/firms having requisite experience in similar nature of works for the following works. Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in. The Bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in.

মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নির্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ, অসম, চান্দমাৰি, গুৱাহাটী-০৩ এ অসমৰ ৰাজ্যপালৰ হৈ, তলত উল্লেখ কৰা কামসমূহৰ বাবে একে ধৰণৰ কামৰ প্ৰয়োজনীয় অভিজ্ঞতা থকা যোগ্য ঠিকাদাৰ/প্ৰতিষ্ঠানৰ পৰা নিবিদা আশ্বাৱজ্ঞ অনাইছা। নিবিদাৰ বিৱৰণ ই-প্ৰকিউৰমেণ্ট পৰ্টেল বেৱছাইট অৰ্থাৎ www.assamtenders.gov.in ত চাব পাৰিব। নিবিদাকাৰীসকল www.assamtenders.gov.in ত পঞ্জীয়নভুক্ত হ'ব লাগিব।

Sl. No. ক্র. নং	Name of work কামৰ নাম	Approx. Value of work (in Rs) কামৰ আনুমানিক মূল্য (টকাত)	Bid Security নিবিদা পত্ৰ সুৰক্ষা	Bid Processing Fee নিবিদা প্ৰক্ৰিয়াকৰণ মূল্য (টকাত)	Completion period সম্পূৰ্ণ কৰাৰ সময়সীমা
1.	Recovery & Reconstruction 32 nos of fully damaged AWCs approved under PDNA 2022 of Barpeta District বৰপেটা জিলাৰ PDNA 2022 অনুসৰি অনুমোদিত সম্পূৰ্ণৰূপে ক্ষতিগ্ৰস্ত ৩২টা অংগনৱাড়ী কেন্দ্ৰ (AWCs)-ৰ পুনৰুদ্ধাৰ আৰু পুনৰ্নিৰ্মাণ।	1,92,00,000.00 ১,৯২,০০,০০০.০০	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	Rs. 3,840.00 ৩,৮৪০.০০	2+4=6 (Six) Months ৬ মাহ (ছয় মাহ)
2.	Recovery & Reconstruction 97 nos of severely damaged AWCs approved under PDNA 2022 of Barpeta District. বৰপেটা জিলাৰ PDNA 2022 অনুসৰি অনুমোদিত গুৰুতৰভাৱে ক্ষতিগ্ৰস্ত ৯৭টা অংগনৱাড়ী কেন্দ্ৰ (AWCs)-ৰ পুনৰুদ্ধাৰ আৰু পুনৰ্নিৰ্মাণ।	2,91,00,000.00 ২,৯১,০০,০০০.০০	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	5,820.00 ৫,৮২০.০০	3+5=8 (Eight) Months ৮ (আঠ) মাহ

Note টিপ্পনি:

(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT. কামৰ মূল্য বিতংভাৱে আহ্বান কৰা নিবিদা জাননী অনুযায়ী পৰিৱৰ্তন হ'ব পাৰে।

(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. সকলো চৰ্ত আৰু নিয়মাবলী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰ অনুযায়ী হ'ব।

(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents. নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰৰ অংশ হ'ব।

Chief Engineer PWD (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.
মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ,

DIPR/C/PIO/104/24-Jun-26

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of M/s. Kanchan Devi who is purchasing Built-up Property bearing No. 2798/1, area measuring 66.33 sq. yards situated in the area of Jwala Nagar, Ilasa Shahdara, New Delhi-110032 New Delhi: East Delhi from Mr. Parveen Kumar who had owned the subject property vide Ration/Quintment Deed dated 12.09.2018 bearing Document No. 7755, Book No. 1, Vol. No.1611, Page No.161-164 dated 13.09.2018. SRO IVB, Delhi, now Mrs. Kanchan Devi is intend to purchase the said property and same to be incorporated with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD SO, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice, so that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP A-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Commercial Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact & 011-40463316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that the Certificate(s) of the under mentioned Equity Shares of M/s RRP Defense Ltd (formerly known as Interad Exports Ltd and Euro Asia Exports Ltd) have been lost/misplaced and the holder(s) of Purchase(s) of the said Equity Shares have applied to the company to issue duplicate Share Certificate(s). Any person who has a claim in respect of the said Shares should lodge the same with the company at its Registered Office within 15 days from this date else the Company will proceed to issue duplicate Certificate(s) to the aforesaid applicants without any further intimation

Folio No.	Name of Shareholder
128	VALUENE SECURITIES PVT LTD
No. of Shares	Dist Nos. Fm. To
4500	888601- 873100
Cert.No Fm. To -	00050029

FOR VALUENE SECURITIES PVT LTD
SHIVAM PRAKASH GUPTA
Place: Delhi, Dated: 24.06.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is hereby informed that Entire Second Floor without roof rights of the Freehold Property No. 21, Block C, commonly known as (C-21), area measuring 330.00 sq. yds, Green Park, New Delhi, presently owned and possessed by Smt. Sharada Devi Dhanrajani by virtue of Sale Deed duly registered vide Regd. No. 191423/2024, dated 06.08.2024 and the same is proposed to be offered as Security with State Bank of India, Branch: Home Loan Centre, Central, Thagar House, New Delhi and as per present owner's version the said property is/are free from all sorts of encumbrance. The ORIGINAL Sale Deed executed by Urban Improvement Housing and Construction Company Pvt Ltd in favor of Smt. Santosh Shaila, duly registered vide Regd. No. 1080, dated 12.03.1959 is reported as lost vide LR No. 191423/2024, dated 10.07.2024 with Crime Branch, Delhi Police, Delhi.

It is hereby notified that any person and/or Bank/financial institution having any claim, any charge, interest or lien or claim and/or objection to/thereon, he/she/they may lodge/notify the same to the undersigned with documentary proof/court judgment within 15 days from the day of publication of this public notice, failing which any further claim/objection(s) shall be rejected and any client/prospective buyer (s) as a bona-fide purchaser claiming the title/ Sale Deed proposed to be executed in favor of my client or in the name of his/her/their nominees shall be deemed to be clear and marketable without any defect encumbrance, flaw and impediment.

SATYENDER YADAV (ADVOCATE)
Chamber no. 561, 5th Floor, Saket Courts, New Delhi, Mob.: 9711212421, E-mail: satender175@gmail.com

Minor girl abducted, raped and murdered, cab driver arrested

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

In a shocking incident, an 11-year-old girl was allegedly abducted while sleeping beside her family on a pavement in Delhi's Mehrauli area, sexually assaulted, and then strangled to death.

The police have arrested the accused, a 30-year-old cab driver identified as Bashu, within six hours of the crime being reported. According to officials, the accused dumped the child's body in a dense, forested stretch along the Faridabad-Gurgaon road in a desperate attempt to conceal the crime.

The tragedy came to light in the early hours of Monday when the victim's family

woke up and discovered the girl was missing from her usual spot on the footpath. Sensing foul play and suspecting kidnapping, the frantic family members alerted the local police.

"We received information about the incident around 5 am on Monday. Recognising the gravity of the situation, a large-scale search operation was launched immediately," said Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), South District, Anant Mittal. "Nearly 20 dedicated teams were formed to trace the child and track the suspect's movements."

DCP Mittal noted that police teams relied heavily on technical surveillance and analysed a vast network of CCTV footage from the area,

which proved crucial in identifying the suspect's vehicle. After committing the crime, Bashu actually attempted to drive back to the abduction site, but fled upon spotting police teams already on the scene, said a police official.

"Our teams tracked his movements swiftly, and we managed to arrest the accused by 11 am the same day," DCP Mittal added. During sustained interrogation, Bashu confessed to the crime, detailing how he abducted the minor, sexually assaulted her, and then choked her to death.

Acting on the disclosures made by the accused during questioning, police teams recovered the child's body from the forested stretch late



Monday afternoon. The body was subsequently sent for a post-mortem examination to ascertain the exact medical cause of death and to secure essential medico-legal evidence required for court proceedings.

Forensic experts thoroughly examined both the Mehrauli footpath, where the girl was allegedly abducted and the isolated spot where her body was abandoned. Multiple forensic samples have been collected for

detailed scientific analysis.

The victim's background highlights harrowing poverty. The family, originally from Bihar, consists of four children and daily-wage labourers. They previously lived in a rented home in Delhi but lost their accommodation due to financial hardship and were forced onto the pavements. Reports noted that the young 11-year-old girl sold balloons to help her parents make ends meet.

Additionally, the victim's autopsy was completed by Tuesday afternoon. Police officials added that further legal proceedings were underway and that they were probing whether the accused acted entirely alone, as well as other details about him.

GRIEF, ANGUISH ENGULF CHATTARPUR AS FAMILY CREMATES 11-YEAR-OLD GIRL

New Delhi: Grief and anguish engulfed a crematorium in south Delhi's Chattarpur on Tuesday as the family of an 11-year-old girl, who was allegedly abducted, raped and murdered in Mehrauli, bid her a tearful farewell.

The minor's body was brought to the crematorium amid heavy police deployment, with officers stationed in and around the premises to maintain law and order.

The child's family members were inconsolable. They repeatedly broke down

and had to be supported by relatives as they struggled to come to terms with the loss.

Several family members were seen lying on the ground, crying uncontrollably. Many relatives fainted during the cremation and were assisted by those present. The atmosphere at the crematorium was filled with cries of grief as mourners gathered around the bereaved family.

"We have lost everything. The accused must be given capital punishment," a man shouted.

Govt to conduct structural audit of 44 flyovers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To ensure public safety, the Delhi Government's Public Works Department plans to conduct a structural audit of 44 flyovers that are 15 years old to assess their health and fitness.

According to PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma, the PWD, which manages around 100 flyovers in the city, has decided to hire a consultant to carry out the survey of the flyovers older than 15 years and submit a report to the Government. Most of the flyovers in Delhi are 10 to 15 years old.

"Public safety cannot wait for a crisis. Many of our flyovers have been serving citizens for more than 15 years and carry lakhs of commuters every day. By initiating a comprehensive structural audit of such flyovers, we are taking a proactive and scientific approach to assess their condition," Verma said.

Among the flyovers that



will be taken up for repairs this year is the one at Shadipur in West Delhi, the first modern flyover in the city, which was opened to traffic back in February 1971.

Repairs of the Zakhira flyover, which was also built in the 1970s, and the Raja Garden, Seelampur, Peeragarhi, IIT, and Modi Mill flyovers, as well as the Barapullah Nullah culvert, are also likely to begin in 2026, officials said.

Officials said the flyovers need repair of expansion joints or spalled concrete

and in some cases the core structure or replacement of the elastomeric bearing connecting the slabs with the base. The oldest flyovers will be repaired first, especially those that were constructed before 2000, as they require immediate attention.

An expansion joint is a small gap that provides space for the concrete to expand and contract. It is an iron joint placed between concrete slabs to prevent damage to concrete and absorb vibrations. The repair work focuses primarily on

replacing expansion joints and elastomeric bearings - components that absorb stress, temperature-related expansion, and the constant weight of traffic.

"By initiating a comprehensive structural audit of 44 such flyovers, we are taking a proactive and scientific approach to assess their condition, identify any potential concerns at an early stage, and plan timely interventions wherever required. This exercise is not merely an inspection; it is an investment in the safety, confidence, and convenience of Delhi's citizens. Our government is committed not only to creating new infrastructure but also to ensuring that existing public assets remain strong, secure, and capable of serving future generations. Through this initiative, we are reinforcing our commitment to preventive maintenance, transparency, and world-class urban infrastructure standards for the people of Delhi," Verma added.

Health scheme for construction workers approved

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday approved a health scheme for registered construction workers and their family members, providing them up to ₹10 lakh cashless medical treatment cover.

The decision was taken in a cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. The move will benefit around 2.70 lakh registered building and other construction workers as well as their families. The Government expects to spend approximately ₹200 crore annually on the scheme.

The scheme aims to strengthen social security and healthcare services for the registered workers. Besides annual health check-ups for workers and their families, a range of medical services will be provided free of cost. The entire treatment process will be cashless, ensuring that workers and their families do not have to bear any financial burden.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the Delhi Government is working with full sensitivity and commitment for the welfare of every section of society, particularly the poor, workers and underprivileged families. She said construction workers are the foundation of the capital's development, and strengthening their health and social security remains a key priority of the government.

It is with this objective that the Cabinet has approved this important health scheme.

She said construction

workers are routinely exposed to stone-cutting dust, chemicals, excessive noise, heavy machinery, general dust and physically demanding working conditions. As a result, they remain vulnerable to silicosis (a lung disease), respiratory ailments, skin disorders and other serious health problems. She noted that a comprehensive health protection scheme for this section had long been lacking, and the present initiative has been designed to address that gap.

Elaborating upon the

scheme, the Chief Minister said registered construction workers and their eligible family members, including spouses, children and parents, will receive free and quality healthcare services through empanelled hospitals and mobile health units.

Each registered worker will be entitled to treatment of up to ₹2 lakh at empanelled hospitals, while the limit for a family will be up to ₹10 lakh. The entire treatment process will be cashless, eliminating any financial burden on workers and their families.

The scheme will also provide annual health check-ups for registered workers and their spouses. In addition, beneficiaries will have access to free OPD and IPD services, diagnostic and laboratory facilities, emergency medical assistance and referral services. Healthcare services will also be delivered through Mobile Medical Units at construction sites and in areas with a high concentration of workers.

Rain, thunderstorms bring relief from heat



People cover themselves as they walk amid rainfall PANKAJ KUMAR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rain lashed several parts of Delhi on Tuesday afternoon, leading to a sharp drop in temperatures across the national capital, with the weather department forecasting more rain in the second half of the week.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) data, the city's maximum temperature rose slightly, but thunderstorm activity brought the temperature down in several parts of Delhi.

Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, recorded a maximum temperature of 40.1 degrees Celsius, 1.5

notches above normal and 1.7 degrees higher than the previous day.

The minimum temperature settled at 26.8 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches below the normal and 0.5 degrees lower than the day before.

IMD data showed that Safdarjung received 8.4 mm of rain between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm, along with winds reaching up to 52 kmph at 2.30 pm, leading to a seven-degree temperature drop.

Other weather stations also recorded significant wind speed along with rain, with the highest being at Palam, where the wind speed reached 91 kmph at 2.30 pm.

7 sewage treatment plants fail discharge standards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Pollution Control Committee's (DPCC) monthly assessment found that at least seven sewage treatment plants breached the prescribed discharge limits for total suspended solids, biochemical oxygen demand and faecal coliform in May.

Testing standards across more than 30 STPs in the national capital, the report provides data for samples collected from both inlet and outlet points.

Flagging the STP at Yamuna Vihar Ph-III for non-compliance, the report said the outlet sample from the facility exceeded the set limits for total suspended solids, biological oxygen demand and faecal coliform.

According to the report by the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC), the treated discharge from the STP showed a faecal coliform level of 7,600 MPN/100 ml against the permissible level of 230 MPN/100 ml.

The outlet sample at



Yamuna Vihar Ph-III also showed a TSS level of 17 mg/l against the prescribed limit of 10 mg/l and BOD of 28 mg/l against the permissible level of 10 mg/l.

The sample collected from the STP at Mehrauli showed a faecal coliform level of 15,000 MPN/100 ml, along with high TSS, BOD, ammoniacal nitrogen and dissolved phosphate.

The other STPs that have not met the prescribed limits included those at Yamuna Vihar Ph-I, Ghitorni, Coronation Pillar and two in Vasant Kunj.

The STP at Ghitorni showed extremely high level of faecal coliform, reaching up to 17,000 MPN/100 ml, as compared to 16,000 MPN/100 ml in April and 17,000 MPN/100 ml in March.

Delhi Zoo overcrowded as blackbuck, chital populations exceed enclosure capacity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The number of blackbuck, spotted deer (chital), sangai deer, and barking deer at the Delhi zoo is now much higher than the enclosures can hold. In some cases, there are more than three times the recommended number of animals.

Officials say it is still difficult to manage the number of herbivores, even though they have been moving some animals to other places in recent years.

The largest gap has been recorded in the blackbuck (kala mrig) population, with 143 animals against a recommended capacity of 40. Chital numbers stand at 85



against a capacity of 30, while kala mrig (black deer) has reached 80 against the prescribed limit of 2. Similarly, there are 66 sangai deer, but space for only 20. The number of barking deer (para hiran) is 56, though the limit is 20. There are 36 sambar and 36 nilgai, both

above the recommended 20. There are also 15 wild boar, while the enclosure is meant for just four, he said. 15 against four, he said.

To address overcrowding, the National Zoological Park has moved additional herbivores to other wildlife centres over the past two to

three years. About 110 animals were sent to Vantara in Gujarat. More than 150 animals, including blackbuck, sangai deer, and barking deer (kakar), went to Rajasthan's Mukundra Hills Tiger Reserve as part of efforts to manage the population," he said. The problem also affects birds. The zoo official said there are about 90 painted storks, though the recommended number is 25. There are 44 jungle fowl, but the limit is 15.

He said that even after moving some animals, many herbivore populations are still above the recommended limits. Many enclosures, especially those for deer and antelope, now have more animals than they can hold.



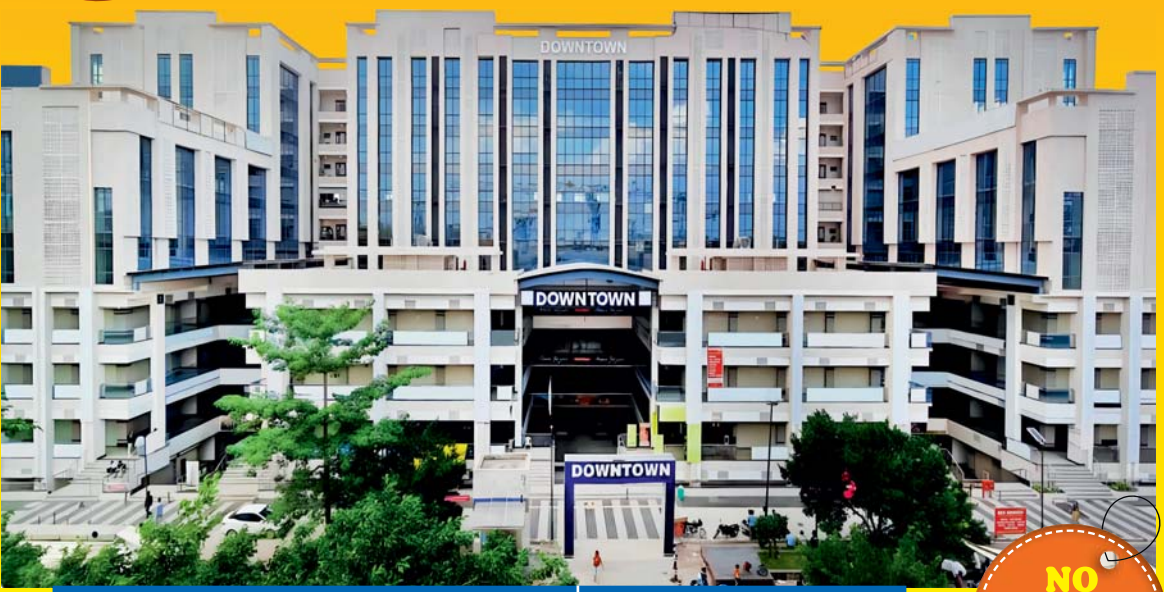
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IN FOCUS



People participate in a procession ahead of Muharram in Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir

PTI

Govt flags rain deficit; 315 districts face Kharif risk

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The delayed monsoon in India has rung alarm bells, forcing the Government to go into firefighting mode. Faced with a 43 per cent rain deficit so far, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Chouhan on Tuesday admitted it will adversely impact the sowing of kharif crops and said the Government is making preparations to mitigate the looming challenge in 315 districts identified as most vulnerable to crop damage.

States have been asked to use water judiciously and to clean ponds, streams, farm ponds and check dams under the VB-GRAM G (Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin) programme to preserve water for irrigation contingencies.

The ministry has mapped 315 districts across Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Bihar, Jharkhand,



Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Chouhan

Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and Odisha – as likely to receive below-normal rainfall. Of these, 111 districts – including 20 in Maharashtra – have been classified as “most vulnerable” owing to irrigation cover of less than 25 per cent. Another 76 districts with 25–50 per cent irrigation fall in the “medium vulnerable” category, while 128 districts with adequate dam and irrigation infra-

structure are tagged “least vulnerable.” A majority of these districts are located across 12 states—Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Bihar, Jharkhand, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Odisha. Detailed discussions were held with Agriculture Ministers and District Collectors of these states, and they were urged to

expedite preparedness at the local level. India received 60 mm rainfall as against the normal of 120 mm between June 1 and June 23. Several key agricultural states have recorded sharp deficit of rainfall, raising concerns over the kharif crops plantation which relies heavily on monsoon rains. More than half of India's kharif arable land is rain-fed. Among the worst-affected states, Maharashtra and Gujarat have reported rainfall deficit around 70 to 74 percent so far.

Sharing details, Chouhan said weak monsoon conditions were likely to persist until July 2, leaving little time for farmers to plant the kharif (summer) crop. As of June 22, sowing of kharif crops covered less than 10 per cent of total sown area - marginally higher than the 11.79 million hectare recorded in the year-ago period, at 11.99 million hectare - with most crops tracking ahead except soyabean. “Overall, there is a 43 per cent deficit in monsoon rains. IMD forecasts that the weak

monsoon is likely to continue till July 2. It means, kharif crops could be impacted,” Chouhan told reporters after the review meeting on monsoon progress.

“There is a gap in rainfall. We need to suggest to farmers to go for alternative crops. We will not let farm fields remain empty,” the minister said. Seed and fertiliser availability is adequate for the season, he added. Reservoir levels are currently above last year's position, though declining. The ministry has called for extensive enrolment under crop insurance schemes and Kisan Credit Cards in the identified states.

The 731 Krishi Vigyan Kendras (KVKs) have been asked to step up farmer outreach, with timely advisories to be disseminated via SMS, WhatsApp, call centres, and other media. On production estimates, Chouhan said the forecasts are based on normal conditions but affirmed, “We will ensure production does not fall” he added.

Delhi Police crack ₹1.5 crore armed robbery, 8 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police cracked a sensational ₹1.5 crore armed robbery case, arresting six accused individuals and apprehending two juveniles after an 11-day search spanning eight states and covering nearly 4,000 kilometres, officials said on Tuesday.

The robbery occurred on June 10 near Zakhira Flyover in the Sarai Rohilla area when complainant Nitin and his associate Karan were transporting around ₹1.5 crore in cash on a scooter. Two unidentified men riding a motorcycle intercepted them. One assailant, armed with a pistol, robbed them of two bags containing the cash before fleeing.

Police said the case took a dramatic turn when investigators discovered that Karan, an employee of the victim company, masterminded the robbery and allegedly leaked information about the cash movement to his criminal



associates. A specialised team launched an extensive investigation, examining footage from nearly 500 CCTV cameras and mapping the suspects' route.

The analysis revealed that the robbers started following the victims from Paschim Vihar and used multiple vehicles, including a motorcycle,

a scooty and a Maruti Swift car, to execute the crime and escape. The breakthrough came after police traced a scooter used in the offence to a juvenile. Two juveniles were apprehended on June 19, leading investigators to Viresh alias Veeru, who was arrested the following day. His interrogation led to the arrest

of Manpreet alias Twinkle and Karan. Police later arrested Manpreet's father, Charanjeet Singh, for allegedly helping in the conspiracy. Investigators subsequently identified two key accused, Vicky alias Ganja and Dhir Singh, through the Swift car used in the operation. After the robbery, the duo alleged-

ly travelled through Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Haryana, Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir to evade arrest. Police teams pursued them continuously for 11 days before finally intercepting and arresting them while they were returning to Delhi from Jammu on June 22.

According to police, Karan had been sharing the cash's live location and movement details with the gang. After the robbery, the accused assembled in Tilak Nagar, where they divided the loot before dispersing.

Delhi Police recovered ₹1.015 crore from the accused and seized the motorcycle and scooter used in the crime. Mobile phones allegedly purchased using the stolen money were also recovered. Police said Vicky and Dhir Singh are history-sheeters with multiple criminal cases registered against them. Further investigation is underway.

Matrimonial fraud racket busted in Delhi; foreigner, partner arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police's Dwarka district unit arrested an over-staying foreign national of the Ivory Coast and his live-in partner from Nagaland for allegedly running an online matrimonial fraud racket that targeted women on marriage websites and duped them of money.

The accused have been identified as Kouadio Victor Nda, 36, of the Ivory Coast, and AneiKonyak, 30, of Nagaland. Police said Nda had overstayed in India and was allegedly involved in cyber fraud operations, while Konyak assisted him in withdrawing the cheated money and contacting victims.

The Anti-Narcotics Cell team arrested the individuals during a raid at a house in Hastals Vihar near Holy Chowk in Uttam Nagar. The operation followed surveillance of sus-



pected cyber fraudsters operating in the area. Investigators said the accused allegedly approached women through matrimonial websites under the pretext of marriage and later cheated them financially. During the raid, police recovered four debit cards linked to mule bank accounts, a laptop, five mobile phones and a passport.

A preliminary examination of the seized debit cards revealed links to a cyber fraud complaint registered at Chabua police station in Assam's Dibrugarh district. Further analysis of the mobile phones allegedly uncovered details of multiple

bank accounts connected to another cyber crime complaint. Police said Konyak played a key role in the operation by withdrawing money from ATMs to avoid suspicion that could arise if a foreign national carried out the transactions.

She allegedly contacted victims cheated by the syndicate. Police records show the accused has no previous criminal record. A case has been registered under relevant provisions of the BharatiyaNyayaSanhita and the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, at the Uttam Nagar police station. Deputy Commissioner of Police Kushal Pal Singh said further investigation is underway to identify and apprehend other members of the cyber fraud network. Police are also examining the digital evidence recovered from the accused to ascertain the full extent of the alleged racket.

FROM PAGE - 1

MHA tightens FCRA rules

Categories include rural, economic, educational, and social. Religious activities include the construction and maintenance of places of worship, religious education, the promotion of devotional music, and similar work.

Critically, several entries exclude proselytisation. These include religious education, documentation of faith traditions, preservation of indigenous beliefs, and the conduct of 'satsangs' or meditation retreats. This deliberate carve-out permits faith-based work while drawing a clear line against conversion activities funded by foreign contributions, clarifying the boundary of permitted activity.

The government now defines 'key functionary' more broadly. It includes directors, partners, trustees of a Hindu undivided family, and anyone who manages the organisation. Usually, if a key functionary is a foreign national (except for people of Indian origin), the group will not get registration or permission. The Government can make exceptions, but the general rule is strict.

NGOs registered before 2026 have one year to declare their chosen purposes and areas of work, and must update their certificates. To renew, they now need to show they spent at least ₹10 lakh on their declared activities in the last two years. This means only active NGOs can renew easily. Groups with prior permission will receive additional foreign funds only after using at least 75 per cent of the previous amount, as verified during a field visit. If funds go through intermediaries or donor-advised funds, the final source must be revealed for transparency.

Annual returns now need a detailed activity report and financial statements. Applicants also have to share their social media account details, which adds to the disclosure requirements.

Overall, these changes move from general oversight to strict, purpose-based control. The Government says the goal is to ensure accountability and stop misuse. The rules also treat foreign funding as a potential source of outside influence in sensitive areas such as religious conversion, political activism, and social movements. These policies affect more than just compliance; they shape how foreign funding impacts civic work. This is a debated topic. Limits on foreign nationals in key roles and full donor disclosure raise concerns about hidden or complex funding. At the same time, the rules make operations harder. NGOs working in many states or on different issues will face higher costs and less flexibility.

The minimum spending rule and the staged release of funds may push smaller groups to spend money quickly rather than plan carefully. The one-year transition period for current NGOs is helpful. But having to specify purposes and locations can lock organisations into certain paths. Requiring social media details gives regulators more ways to watch how groups communicate with the public.

These new rules are part of a ten-year trend

toward stricter FCRA enforcement. Since the 2010 Act, changes and cancellations have steadily reduced what foreign-funded civil society groups can do. The latest updates bring tougher financial penalties and clear up any confusion that has allowed NGOs to interpret their roles more broadly.

Whether these rules prevent misuse without hindering genuine development and charitable work will depend on how they are implemented. Together, higher penalties, specific licensing, geographic limits, spending rules, and more disclosure mean foreign funding in India is now under tighter control, with stricter limits for organisations.

Iran's respect key to resolving war: Trump

In the markets, Brent crude oil fell 3.2 per cent to \$77.52 per barrel, closer to its roughly \$70 price from before the war. Benchmark US crude oil fell 2.6 per cent to \$73.86 per barrel.

President has heralded the peace talks with Iran as a win for US farmers, saying that the unfreezing of sanctioned Iranian money will be tied to that country buying American-grown corn, soybeans and wheat.

“These are things that are desperately needed by Iran,” Trump posted on social media. “This is a humanitarian crisis, and I feel it is necessary to help.” But Iran is unlikely to start buying a vast amount of US farm products.

“I don't expect that trade would be very large in the short run,” said Joseph Glauber, a research fellow emeritus at the International Food Policy Research Institute.

Glauber noted that Iran was “unlikely” to abandon its other trade partners on food for America. He said Iran's major suppliers include Brazil, India, Türkiye, the European Union, Canada, Australia and Argentina and that Trump's demand to buy from the US would “create some hard feelings with some of our competitors.”

11 Indian ships safely transit Strait of Hormuz

The vessels that have made the journey include three Indian-flagged crude oil tankers, each loaded with over 285,000 metric tonnes of crude oil, one foreign-flagged LPG carrier, one foreign-flagged crude oil tanker, and six foreign-flagged bulk carriers carrying fertiliser cargo.

Jaiswal expressed optimism about the remaining ships, stating, “We hope that the remaining India-flagged vessels would also be able to cross the Hormuz soon.”

The Strait of Hormuz is a critical chokepoint for global oil trade, with nearly 20 per cent of the world's petroleum passing through it daily. The successful transit of these vessels comes as a major relief for India, which relies heavily on crude oil and fertiliser imports from the Gulf region. The US-Iran MoU is being seen as a key diplomatic breakthrough that has helped de-escalate tensions, allowing safer passage for mer-

chant shipping in one of the world's busiest and most sensitive maritime routes.

SIT submits preliminary report in Ayodhya row

The Ram Temple in Ayodhya is one of India's most significant religious landmarks. Located at the site revered as Lord Rama's birthplace, it was inaugurated on January 22, 2024, after the 2019 Supreme Court verdict that cleared the way for construction. Since then, the temple has attracted lakhs of pilgrims' daily and generated substantial donations in cash, gold, silver, jewellery, and other valuables.

These offerings support the trust's temple maintenance, security, development works, and charitable initiatives. Questions about their management have drawn widespread attention and underscored the need for transparency.

The temple trust's request for an SIT probe reflects its stated commitment to addressing concerns and upholding accountability. The three-member team, led by Pant and including senior police officers, spent several days in Ayodhya questioning trust officials, staff, and others, while reviewing records and examining evidence, including CCTV footage.

The episode has sparked political debate. The opposition, led by the Samajwadi Party, has called for greater transparency and swift resolution. The temple trust and the state government have said that the inquiry was initiated to ensure proper scrutiny and that it will be conducted fairly.

As the SIT continues its work and prepares the final report, attention remains on Ayodhya. The outcome is expected to clarify the allegations and may recommend measures to strengthen oversight and transparency at the temple.

Sources say the SIT has found systemic lapses in donation handling, including negligence in cash withdrawals from hundis, transport to counting centres, the counting process, and the movement of cash to the bank.

Inadequate CCTV surveillance and monitoring were also cited. Employees allegedly positioned themselves in front of cameras before incidents. Poor employee verification and hiring practices were also noted, including reliance on recommendations and examples of familial appointments in cash-counting roles.

Non-adherence to the prescribed dress code or uniforms by staff handling cash was also reported. A lack of proper checks on what employees carried into or out of the premises was also noted.

Discrepancies in valuables were also reported, with issues in documentation, inventory, storage, and accounting for gold, silver jewellery, precious stones, and diamonds offered by devotees. Trust officials reportedly could not provide satisfactory explanations for certain records.

The probe was expanded to include high-traffic periods, such as Maha Kumbh donations, as well as land purchases by the trust and procurement processes. Around 150 individuals surfaced during questioning, and action is reportedly likely

against approximately 25 persons, though figures vary slightly across reports.

Recoveries reportedly total around ₹2 crore, based on information from the primary accused or employees. SIT is believed to have recommended certain steps to improve systems for cash handling, counting, CCTV coverage, employee verification, and overall transparency.

Appoint a professional Chief Executive Officer (CEO) for the temple trust, modelled on arrangements at Kashi Vishwanath Temple.

Take action against personnel involved in counting and banking processes; the SIT reportedly ensured the removal of previously involved staff. Possible broader measures include a five-year audit of donations and tighter oversight of trust operations.

No guns, just grit: National Tug of War...

He said the Championship is being organised under the aegis of the Tug of War Federation of India (TWFI) in association with the Jammu and Kashmir Tug of War Association in Kulgam. He said approximately 1,000 Athletes from 18 States across India have arrived in Kulgam to participate in the Championship.

He further said it is a traditional strength-based game, and we want to groom the talent at the ground level so that players can compete at the international level after receiving proper training. He said the local organisers have extended all possible help to successfully organise the Championship in the valley.

Organisers highlighted that hosting a national-level Tug of War championship in Quimoh, Kulgam, is a matter of pride for the district and reflects the growing sports culture in Jammu and Kashmir.

Fiancée, lover held in Pune trader murder

Around 10:30 am, he fell nearly 400 feet into a gorge. Goyal told police he slipped while posing for photos near the cliff edge.

Rescue teams recovered his body after a long search. At first, police registered the case as an accidental death. However, Agarwal's family doubted this explanation, and their concerns led Pune Rural Police to investigate further.

Investigators found inconsistencies in statements and checked phone records, call details, and other technical evidence. They also reviewed the couple's earlier visits to the fort and a cancelled pre-wedding trip to Bali.

According to police, Goyal was in a relationship with Chaudhary for about a year, even though she was engaged to Agarwal. She reportedly did not want to marry Agarwal. Police described the conspiracy as unfolding in several steps: First, they travelled to Bali for a pre-wedding photo shoot where Agarwal's passport went missing at Mumbai airport, forcing them to cancel the trip. Police allege Goyal hid or destroyed the passport.

Police say Goyal convinced Agarwal to visit Lohagad Fort several times. On June 14, an earlier attempt to push him reportedly failed when they staged a fake snake scare. On June 18, police allege that Chaudhary was at the fort or called there. As Agarwal and Goyal walked to a secluded spot near the edge, Chaudhary followed. The two then allegedly pushed Agarwal while he was taking photos, making it look like an accident.

Pune Rural Police chief Sandeep Singh Gill said, “Our probe has revealed that Siya and Chetan were in a relationship. Siya was engaged to Ketan, but she did not want to marry him. So she and Chetan hatched a conspiracy. Siya took Ketan to Lohagad Fort on June 18. Chetan was already there. As the two climbed up the hill fort, Chetan followed them. Then he and Siya pushed Ketan off the cliff.”

Both Goyal and Chaudhary were arrested on Tuesday. Police said they have admitted their involvement. The case has now been changed from accidental death to murder, and the investigation is ongoing. Agarwal's father, Vishal Agarwal, said he was shocked and grieving. He shared that his son went on the trek even though he sensed Goyal's reluctance, and wondered why she had not just ended the engagement, as it sent shockwaves through Pune's business community, where the Agarwal family is well known. The wedding preparations, including a reportedly lavish ceremony, had been at an advanced stage.

Lohagad Fort, a popular trekking spot near Lonavala, has seen several accidents due to its cliffs and limited safety barriers. This case may lead to renewed calls for better safety at tourist sites. Police say more arrests are possible as the investigation continues.

Amid Cabinet reshuffle buzz, PM...

Kurian was Union Minister of State for Minority Affairs and also for fisheries, animal husbandry and dairying. Bittu, whose Rajya Sabha term ended on June 21, has also not been renominated by the BJP to the Upper House. He had been a Rajya Sabha member from Rajasthan since August 2024 and also holds the charge as the Minister of State for the Ministry of Food Processing Industries, as well as MoS Railways.

Recently, some of the Union ministers have been given key organisational responsibilities in their home States. BJP President Nitin Nabin, during the last couple of months, has held a series of meetings, which include one with the Prime Minister. It is understood that meetings have taken place to discuss a complete overhaul of the organisational structure of the BJP and also changes in the Council of Ministers.

Ahead of the celebrations of the completion of 12 years of the NDA Government-led by Modi as Prime Minister, a review meeting of the performance of the Council of Ministers was chaired by the PM last month. Government sources said a reshuffle was also awaited to get over certain clarity on realignments of the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs from TMC, Shiv Sena,



12 YEARS OF MARITIME TRANSFORMATION

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“ We Indians are the inheritors of a glorious maritime heritage, and it is the endeavour of our Government to restore India's position of eminence in the global maritime sector.

~ Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

12 YEARS BY THE NUMBERS

1,668 MMT

Total cargo handled at Indian ports, a 59% rise from 1,052 MMT

2,818 MMT

Total port capacity, an 81% rise from 1,561 MMT

218 MMT

Cargo on national waterways, a 652% rise from just 29 MMT

3.23 LAKH

Indian seafarers deployed globally, up 155% from 1.27 lakh. Women seafarers grew 340%

₹26,583 CR

Major port annual revenue, up 126% from ₹11,760 Cr



India — World No. 1 in Ship Recycling

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PILLARS OF TRANSFORMATION



PORTS

BIGGER & SMARTER

- ₹15,000 Cr Annual maritime CAPEX, up 362% since 2014.
- PPP investment alone surged 836% to ₹8,000 Cr.
- Coastal cargo more than doubled, from 74 to 177 MMT.



WATERWAYS

A REVOLUTION UNDERWAY

- 111 National Waterways notified, up from 5 in 2014.
- Operational waterways grew from 3 to 32.
- Over 10 crore passengers now travel by inland waterways every year.



SHIPBUILDING

RISING TO THE WORLD STAGE

- Mega Shipbuilding push: ~ ₹70,000 Cr
- New dry dock at Cochin Shipyard inaugurated 2024.
- Domestic fleet acquisition plan: 437 vessels worth ₹2.2 lakh Cr.



GREEN TRANSITION

CLEANER SEAS, CLEANER RIVERS

- Renewable energy use at major ports up 30x since 2014.
- India's first hydrogen-powered ferry launched at Varanasi, December 2025
- Green Tug Transition Programme targets zero-emission tugs at all major ports by 2040.



LANDMARK PROJECTS

- ➔ **Jal Marg Vikas Project** — Transforming NW-1 from Haldia to Varanasi, ₹5,061 Cr
- ➔ **Jogighopa IWT Terminal, Assam** — New gateway for Northeast India's trade corridor
- ➔ **Mumbai Marina** — 424 yacht berths, ₹887 Cr, India's first world-class marina, 2028
- ➔ **Vadhvan Port, Maharashtra** — India's future largest container port, ₹76,000 Cr investment
- ➔ **National Maritime Heritage Complex, Lothal** — Envisioned as the world's largest maritime museum
- ➔ **Tuna Tekra Container Terminal, Gujarat** — 2.19 million TEU annual capacity

REFORMS & MILESTONES

- ➔ **3 Indian ports in Global Top 30** — 7 in Global Top 100 (World Bank Container Port Performance Index 2025)
- ➔ **Sagarmala Programme** — 7,100+ km of port connectivity infrastructure across India
- ➔ **11 landmark Acts enacted** — including the Merchant Shipping Act 2025 and Indian Ports Act 2025, replacing colonial-era laws
- ➔ **One Nation One Port Process** — Over 39% reduction in documentation transactions at all 12 major ports
- ➔ **Sea cruise passengers up 328%** — from 1.08 lakh to 4.62 lakh
- ➔ **Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047** — 300+ initiatives targeting 10,000 MMTPA port capacity

12
Saal

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■ States Focus ■



OBSERVE HOLOCAUST DAY FOR 1947 PAK RAID VICTIMS: CHUGH

BJP leader Tarun Chugh on Tuesday said the Jammu and Kashmir Government should observe a 'holocaust day' in memory of the victims of the Pakistan army who raided the then princely State in 1947 disguised as tribal people. "The Pakistan army, disguised as tribal people, attacked here and killed Kashmiri citizens, raped the daughters here, continuously looted Jammu and Kashmir for 96 hours, killing and plundering. It was a holocaust. "The J&K Government should observe a 'Holocaust Day' on this," Chugh, national general secretary of the BJP, said.The BJP leader was here to pay tributes to the founder of Jansangh, Syama Prasad Mookerjee, on his 73rd death anniversary. He said a documentary should be made to depict the events, and it should be shown to everyone.

CBI arrests IAS officer in ₹60 crore scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI arrested senior IAS officer Pankaj Agarwal on Tuesday for allegedly siphoning over ₹60 crore from Haryana Government accounts at IDFC First Bank, officials said.

Agarwal, a 2000-batch IAS officer of the Haryana cadre, served as Principal Secretary in the Education Department from December 10, 2024, to June 16, 2025, and in the Agriculture Department from June 20, 2025, to March 24 this year, according to officials.

The alleged misappropriation involved funds from the Haryana School Shiksha Pariyojana Parishad (HSSPP) and the Haryana State Agriculture Marketing Board



(HSAMB). Agarwal was taken into custody on Monday after investigators found that accounts were opened at the bank's Chandigarh Sector 32 branch in violation of Haryana Government guidelines, and funds were transferred beyond permit-

ted limits. "These accounts were opened during Pankaj Agarwal's tenure as Principal Secretary.

The investigation revealed that fraudulent transactions in these departmental accounts led to the misappropriation of funds, resulting in

a net loss of Rs 60.54 crore to the Government," the CBI spokesperson said. This case is part of a broader CBI investigation into the embezzlement of ₹657 crore from Haryana Government and Chandigarh administration accounts at IDFC First Bank. The illegal transactions resulted in a loss of ₹504 crore to the Haryana Government and ₹153 crore to the Chandigarh administration, according to the spokesperson.

Agarwal is scheduled to appear before the special court on Tuesday. The probe was initiated at the request of the Haryana Government.

"During the investigation, incriminating evidence against Pankaj Agarwal has been collected," the

spokesperson said.

The fraud in these two departments involved the misappropriation of about ₹60.54 crore as part of a larger scam at the Sector 32 IDFC First Bank branch. In total, ₹504 crore from eight Haryana Government departments was siphoned off and routed to shell entities, according to the statement.

The CBI has named 17 accused in its charge sheet in this Haryana case, including six bank officials from IDFC First Bank and AU Small Finance Bank, three Haryana Government public servants, two companies, and six other individuals.

"IAS officer RK Singh, who was arrested in this case in relation to misappropriation in Municipal Corporation

Panchkula, has been remanded in judicial custody after the expiry of his police remand," the spokesperson said.

The CBI is also investigating two related cases in Chandigarh: one involving Chandigarh Smart City and the Chandigarh Municipal Corporation, and another concerning CREST Chandigarh.

The CBI has charge-sheeted five bankers, one CSCL official, and one private individual in the CSCL case; and five bankers, two CREST officials, four private individuals, and two companies in the CREST case. Additionally, one senior Indian Forest Service officer has already been arrested in the CREST case," the spokesperson said.



MANIPUR DEPLOYS CoBRA IN HILLS, BEGINS DE-WEAPONISATION

Manipur Home Minister Govindas Konthoujam on Tuesday said additional security forces, including the newly arrived CoBRA unit of the CRPF, are being deployed in the state's hill districts to tackle disturbances, while "de-weaponisation exercises" have begun. Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of an event here, Konthoujam said the security situation was relatively calmer in the valley areas, urging forces to focus on operations in the hills. "Small things may happen in valley areas. However, disturbances are present in hill areas. We must try to maintain a peaceful atmosphere in valley areas so that security personnel may be able to act in hill areas," he said. The hill areas account for around 90 per cent of Manipur's geographical area and have witnessed heightened tensions in recent months between rival armed groups belonging to tribal communities. "More security forces, including the newly arrived CoBRA unit of CRPF, are being deployed in hill areas to hunt out culprits, as there is less disturbance in valley areas. De-weaponisation exercises have also started," the minister said. "My appeal is that peace must be maintained for a progressive state," he added.

CPI(M) MP Brittias urges Govt to prevent foodgrain spoilage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

CPI(M) Rajya Sabha MP John Brittias has written to Union minister Pralhad Joshi over the issue relating to food-grain storage, highlighting the need to prevent spoilage and reduce dependence on the Cover and Plinth (CAP) open-air storage system used by the Food Corporation of India (FCI).

In a letter to Joshi, the Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Brittias forwarded a representation by the Food Corporation of India Employees Association (CITU), which pointed out that due to constraints in covered storage capacity, substantial quantities of foodgrains continue to be stored in CAP facilities and other open storage spaces in several parts of the country.

The letter said such arrangements, particularly in regions like Kerala, prone to heavy rainfall and high humidity, expose valuable foodgrain stocks to the risk of deterioration and avoidable losses, defeating the



John Brittias



Pralhad Joshi

objective of scientific grain preservation.

It added that with the southwest monsoon setting in over large parts of the country, climatic conditions have made open storage increasingly vulnerable to moisture damage and spoilage.

Brittias said successive audits and expert committees have repeatedly highlighted the need to progressively reduce reliance on CAP storage and augment modern warehousing infrastructure.

Referring to a high-level committee constituted in 2014, he said it had recommended the gradual elimination of CAP storage and transition towards scientific storage systems, including

modern silos and mechanised warehouses.

He further said continued reliance on CAP storage as a long-term arrangement could entail considerable economic and operational costs, especially amid manpower shortages at depots and challenges in upkeep, fumigation and preservation of stocks stored under open conditions.

The CPI(M) leader suggested that resources allocated for construction, renovation and maintenance of CAP structures could instead be redirected towards permanent scientific storage infrastructure, including steel silos, mechanised godowns and climate-controlled facilities.

HD Kumaraswamy seeks farmer participation in talks over Bidadi row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

ID(S) leader HD Kumaraswamy on Tuesday said he is awaiting Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar's response to his letter, seeking rescheduling of a meeting on the proposed GBIT project near Bidadi in Bengaluru South district, and the Government's land acquisition for it.

The Union Minister also stressed that the talks should involve the farmers affected by the project, instead of a few holding a discussion at Vidhana Soudha, as proposed by the CM. Shivakumar had on Monday invited Kumaraswamy to his office at Vidhana Soudha on June 26, for a discussion on the issue.

However, citing prior commitments, Kumaraswamy had sought to reschedule the meeting to June 27, proposing the discussion be organised at a suitable venue in Bidadi or Byramangala instead of Vidhana Soudha, aiming to give affected farmers and villagers an opportunity to participate. Meanwhile, reacting to



Union Minister of Heavy Industries and Steel HD Kumaraswamy addressing a press conference in Bengaluru, Karnataka

Kumaraswamy's letter, Shivakumar told reporters on Tuesday, "Let's not discuss it now. I will get back to you on the matter."

Despite opposition from sections of farmers and villagers, a final notification was recently issued for the acquisition of 499 acres across three villages in Ramanagara and Harohalli taluks for the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township, one of Shivakumar's ambitious projects, projected as India's "first AI-powered integrated township".

The project is expected to cover a total of 7,481 acres across nine villages in the

region, sources said, adding that the notification issued recently is likely the first in a series of land acquisition notifications expected in the coming days.

Rejecting suggestions of challenge or counter challenge on the township issue, Kumaraswamy said, "The farmers have been protesting for over 450 days against the Government's move to acquire lands for the project against their will. The government claims 80 per cent of people have consented to the land acquisition, but farmers state that 70-80 per cent have not consented, creating significant confusion," he said.

Psycho killer poisons 8 men in Chhattisgarh, attends funerals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Balodabazar

A gruesome serial murder spree orchestrated by a "psycho killer" gripped a village in Chhattisgarh's Balodabazar district, where a shopkeeper allegedly used lethal doses of borax powder to poison eight men over a period of four months, police said on Tuesday.

The 46-year-old accused, Ram Sahay Jaiswal, evaded suspicion for months by helping grieving families and even attending the funerals of his victims, police said.

He was arrested on Tuesday following two weeks of investigation and over a month after he killed his last victim.

The chilling murders took place between February and May this year in Khavre village under Kasdol police station limits, officials said.

According to police, Jaiswal, said to be a "psycho killer", carried out the murders driven by feelings of revenge, mental frustration



and long-standing grudges against the victims over minor disputes.

While the deaths had initially been treated as natural or due to some illness, villagers and relatives of the deceased approached police earlier this month, expressing suspicion about Jaiswal's possible involvement, they said.

Given the seriousness of the allegations, police launched a detailed probe, exhuming the body of Jaiswal's last victim, Mahetaru Sahu, who died on May 14, on June 13, Balodabazar-Bhatapara Superintendent of Police (in-charge) OP Sharma said. He said that subsequently, six more bodies were exhumed

and sent to Dr Bhim Rao Ambedkar Memorial Hospital (Mekahara) in Raipur for post-mortem examinations, while the remains of one Budhram Jaiswal could not be recovered as he had been cremated.

A special medico-legal team conducted the autopsies and preserved DNA samples, viscera and other forensic evidence for laboratory analysis, Sharma said.

Police formed multiple teams to investigate the deaths, questioning villagers and monitoring developments on the ground, gathering technical and forensic evidence, he said.

Investigations revealed that the accused had taken 'suhaga' (borax powder) from a villager, claiming that he had needed to kill rats, he said. During questioning, Jaiswal initially denied any role, but eventually confessed that he targeted the victims one after another over old disputes, verbal altercations, allegations of witchcraft and other personal grievances, the senior official said.

Gurdwara standoff resolved peacefully, Nihangs vacate premises

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dehradun

A nearly 72-hour standoff at the Nagarasu gurdwara in Uttarakhand's Rudraprayag ended on Tuesday evening as a group of Nihangs holed up at the shrine vacated the premises after talks with a delegation from Punjabi, officials said.

"The gurdwara management and the police administration worked together to resolve the issue peacefully. All those involved have now left the premises, and normalcy has been restored," Rudraprayag District

Magistrate Vishal Mishra said. Videos circulating on social media showed the Nihang Sikhs leaving the Nagarasu Gurdwara premises on their motorcycles, with police personnel facilitating their safe and orderly exit.

Around half a dozen Nihangs, armed with swords and spears, had stormed the Nagarasu Gurdwara, situated between Rudraprayag and Gauchar on the Badrinath Highway, on the evening of June 20. They climbed onto the roof and blocked the entrance to the terrace. This came after four Nihang Sikhs were



Mann urges State's youths working abroad to return

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bathinda

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Tuesday urged youths of the State working abroad to return to their motherland, assuring them that his Government would provide regular employment opportunities and make them active partners in the state's socio-economic progress.

He said his Government's transparent recruitment process for jobs has restored the faith of youth in the



system and triggered a reverse migration, with many youngsters now choosing to return to the State from abroad instead of seeking opportunities there.

Mann was addressing a gathering at an event where

he handed over appointment letters to 665 newly recruited candidates in Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL).

He said the State has created a record by providing 68,268 Government jobs in just four-and-a-half-years, completely ending the era of cash-for-jobs and recommendations.

Mann urged the youths of Punjab working abroad to return to their motherland, assuring them that the State Government would provide regular employment oppor-

tunities and make them active partners in the State's socio-economic progress.

Targeting the previous governments, Mann said that many youngsters left Punjab and have settled abroad. But reverse migration has started in the State now. "Now things have changed. A reflection of this change can be seen from the fact that a woman present here today has three jobs and is among the successful candidates receiving appointment letters.

Assam Rifles holds educational tour, weapon display for students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

In a major youth outreach initiative, the Assam Rifles organised a multi-faceted educational tour and weapon display at Pallel Garrison in Kakching district on Tuesday, aiming to motivate the younger generation toward public service.

The comprehensive programme, facilitated at the initiative of Lt Gen K Himalay Singh (Retd), Chairman of the Senkon Institute (Navodaya and Sainik), welcomed a large delegation of 229 students and 11 teachers from Charangpat in Thoubal district. The day-long itinerary offered the visiting students a rare, close-up insight into the operational roles, capabilities, and national security responsibilities of the security



forces. During the centrepiece weapon display, Assam Rifles personnel showcased a wide variety of modern weaponry and equipment used in active counter-insurgency and security duties. The students and faculty members were briefed on technical specifications and safety protocols.

Expanding the scope of the exposure, the visitors were taken on a specialised tour of the community radio station, CRS Radio Highway, where they learned about the role of community broadcasting in public outreach and information dissemination.

The tour concluded with a visit to the Cultural Hall at Pallel Garrison, where the delegation was briefed on the rich cultural heritage, traditions, and history of the region.

Maharashtra reported 10,505 cyber fraud cases in over one year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra has registered 10,505 cyber financial fraud cases between January 2025 and May 2026, leading to the arrest of 2,379 accused, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis informed the State Legislative Assembly on Tuesday.

In a written reply to a question raised by several members, Fadnavis, who holds the home portfolio, said Ahilyanagar district recorded 5,141 complaints in 2025 involving digital arrest scams, share trading frauds, hotel rating scams and malicious APK and PDF files, resulting in losses of ₹37.76 crore. Of the amount involved, transactions worth ₹7.02 crore were put on hold, he said. Fadnavis said a retired Government employee from Kopergaon in Ahilyanagar district was duped of ₹87.3 lakh after being threatened with "digital arrest".



Parliamentary panel in J&K briefed on border security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Security officials on Tuesday briefed the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs about the steps taken to protect the country's borders following the success of Operation Sindoor last year.

"Today, we had a very fruitful interaction with the army officers, security officers and defence forces on how they protect our borders and about the performance of our forces during Operation Sindoor," committee member Rajiv Shukla told reporters.

He said the committee was also briefed about the major precautions and preparations for the future and the lessons learned.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, chaired by MP Shashi Tharoor, begun a four-day study visit to Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh on June 22 to review strategic border security and foreign policy issues. The committee will



also visit Kargil and Leh on Wednesday and Thursday to gain first-hand insights into border management and the security situation in frontier areas.

The panel is examining recent developments in India's bilateral relations, the suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty and threats posed by cross-border terrorism along the Line of Control and the international border.

It is also focusing on India-China relations and the situation along the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh.

Tharoor on Monday drew ire of Congress leaders for making remarks about "encouraging progress towards normalcy" in Jammu and Kashmir after a meeting with LG Manoj Sinha.

He clarified, however, that the panel is in the UT not to evaluate conditions in the Valley, and its focus is limited to matters related to foreign affairs, including India-Pakistan and Sino-Indian relations and passport services.

Shukla also said on Tuesday that the purpose of this parliamentary tour is to

address the issue of the country's relations with Pakistan.

"What must we do on the Pakistan border, and what steps should we take going forward to strengthen our security? The army officers briefed us on this and their future requirements and how the work is being done here to give confidence to the local population," he said.

On the peace deal between Iran and the United States, the Congress MP said India was suffering economically due to the conflict.

"We were suffering losses, the whole world was suffering losses because of this ongoing conflict. So the sooner this gets resolved, the sooner peace is restored, the better it is for us and for everyone," he added. Shukla said India wants peace to be restored as soon as possible.

"The Hormuz opening up will benefit us. With the Strait open, around 300-400 of our ships used to come, but right now, very few are able to come. If it opens, our energy crisis will end," he said.

Pressure mounts on UDF Government over low-alcohol beverage tax cut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Pressure is mounting on the Congress-led UDF Government in Kerala to review its decision to reduce taxes on low-alcohol beverages, with key ally IUML expressing concern over the move and the Opposition CPI(M) intensifying its attack.

The latest sign of discomfort within the ruling front came from Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) State president Sadique Ali Shihab Thangal, who said concerns raised over the budget proposal to reduce taxes on low-alcohol beverages should be addressed even as the Government pushes ahead with its anti-drug campaign, 'Operation Toofan'.

In articles published in two Malayalam dailies, Thangal described substance abuse as a grave menace affecting individuals, families and society, and said efforts to build a drug-free Kerala should go hand in hand with addressing apprehensions over the tax concessions announced in the Budget.

"While Operation Toofan to drive out narcotics is being embraced across the State, concerns that have arisen



IUML State president Sadique Ali Shihab Thangal

regarding the liquor tax concessions in the budget should also be allayed," he said.

Thangal said studies indicated that a section of those who initially experiment with intoxicants eventually become habitual users, and stressed the need to create drug-free villages alongside drug-free homes.

He praised the UDF Government's anti-drug initiative and said the public should extend strong support to the campaign.

Referring to the seizure of narcotics worth around ₹10 crore and the arrest of nearly 3,000 people within a short period under Operation Toofan, he termed the drive a significant step against substance abuse.

Thangal's remarks assume significance as political opponents have been questioning the silence of the IUML, a key constituent of the ruling UDF, on the Government's proposal. Meanwhile, senior CPI(M) leader and former finance minister KN Balagopal said the previous LDF Government had opposed such products fearing that their availability at lower prices would encourage "social drinking" and eventually lead to higher alcohol consumption.

He alleged that the Government is not ready to clearly state whether it will withdraw the tax cut proposal or stick to its decision.

Earlier in the day, Balagopal raised the tax cut issue in the state assembly as an adjournment motion during the zero hour, leading to a ruckus in the House, following which the Left opposition staged a walkout.

"Information that has come out shows that the file related to it was processed at a record pace. We want to know how a decision to permit flavoured alcoholic beverages, which had been rejected by our Government, was taken at war-footing speed," he told reporters here.

Congress, Left hold protest rally against SIR process

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Congress, Left parties and TJS on Tuesday took out a rally here protesting what they described as "undemocratic and vote-theft" activities allegedly being carried out through the SIR of electoral rolls by the BJP and Election Commission.

Holding placards, the protesters participated in the rally, which was organised from the BR Ambedkar statue on Tank Bund to the BRK Bhavan. The protesters said they will submit a representation to the Election



Commission. The house-to-house enumeration process under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls would be taken up in Telangana from June 25 to July 24. Election Commission officials said the primary objective of SIR is the purification of electoral rolls and to see to it that all the eligible citizens are included in the electoral rolls.

Lucknow blaze: 14 coaching centres sealed in Jaipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

The Jaipur administration on Tuesday launched a crackdown on coaching institutes and libraries over fire safety violations, sealing 14 establishments and issuing notices to over two dozen others following a deadly blaze at a coaching centre in Lucknow that claimed 15 lives.

Teams of the municipal corporation and police carried out inspections across the city to verify fire safety arrangements, including the availability of fire-fighting equipment, emergency exits and mandatory



fire no objection certificates (NOCs). Chief Fire Officer Devendra Meena said that since June 4, around 600 units in the Heritage area have been issued notices over fire safety compliance, including nearly 150 coaching institutes and libraries.

TN CM hits back at Opposition over inexperienced jibe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Tuesday lashed out at the Opposition DMK on corruption, and for labelling TVK as inexperienced and straight from film, saying his decades-old grassroots track record stretching back to his fan clubs in the 1990s shaped his standing in politics and State administration.

His active service to the people continued in the form of Vijay Makkal Iyakkam, his public advocacy during the 2002 Sri Lankan Tamil crisis, the 2011 Nagapattinam fishermen protests, the 2017 Jallikattu movement and his anti-CAA stance highlighted his active role in public life.

His political journey was long, overcoming several roadblocks, including the blame for the Karur stampede that left 41 dead, the agony over the then government imposing numerous restrictions on his TVK meetings and inadequate protection, and hurdles imposed to prevent him from meeting the people, Vijay said.

He did not transition from acting career to politics effortlessly but had to face several agonising trials, he said in his reply to the debate on the motion of thanks to the Governor for his address to the House.

His blistering attack targeting the DMK on the corruption plank led to the Opposition party members, under their leader Udhayanidhi Stalin, rising up from their seats and demanding proof. Udhayanidhi urged Speaker JCD



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Vijay speaks during the State Legislative Assembly session in Chennai

Prabhakar to permit him to respond, but the Speaker declined, ultimately leading to the DMK members staging a walkout from the Assembly House after an uproar.

Responding to the Opposition barb that the newly formed Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam government lacked experience and that its legislators don't possess "administrative knowledge", the chief minister sarcastically remarked, "You are right, we don't have the knowledge to loot public money. We know how to protect natural resources but not to plunder, we know to float tenders for projects but not for kickbacks, we know how to serve the people and devotees but not how to exploit temple funds."

The TVK Government would ensure the money in the State coffers went

directly to the people and not diverted as "party funds", which the previous DMK regime had done, Vijay said and warned that he would not spare anyone indulging in corrupt practices, even if it is political parties.

He later remarked that his administration would be real and not reel that the opposition has been talking of, and slammed the opposition for calling him an actor and his TVK an actor's party.

The 2026 Assembly election exposed the real picture that he and the TVK were in the people's hearts.

He remained one with the people and then launched the TVK two years ago, unlike other leaders who launch the party first and then try to connect with the people. He expressed his heartfelt gratitude to the people of Tamil Nadu for electing him and his party.

Tenyimi Union demands justice for 6 Nagas killed in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kohima

An apex tribal body in Nagaland on Tuesday strongly condemned the killing of six Nagas in Manipur and demanded immediate arrest and stringent punishment for the perpetrators. It also expressed serious concern over the rising incidence of crimes against women and children.

The resolutions were adopted at the first Annual General Session of the Tenyimi Union Nagaland (TUN), an apex body of five tribes in the State — Anagmi, Chakhesang, Pochury, Rengma and Zeliang — held under the theme "Progressive



society through Unity" at the Angami Gazetted Officers' Krotho Building, Badze, Meriema here.

Adopting a strong resolution, the TUN condemned what it described as the "brutal murder" of six inno-

cent Nagas in Kangpokpi district of Manipur, allegedly by Kuki militants earlier this month.

The union termed the killings "unimaginable, ruthless and inhuman" and called on the Governments of Manipur and India, along with law enforcement agencies, to immediately identify and arrest those responsible.

It demanded that the accused be awarded the severest punishment permissible under the law, warning that any delay in delivering justice could have "serious repercussions."

The union also voiced grave concern over the increasing cases of

crimes against women and children, stating that no society can progress when the dignity and safety of women and children are under constant threat.

Blaming delays in the justice delivery system for emboldening offenders, the TUN called for swift justice in every case of sexual abuse involving women and children. On Naga unity, the union welcomed the initiatives of the Nagaland Tribal Hohos Coordination Committee, saying the committee's efforts to foster unity and brotherhood among Nagas would help protect and safeguard the rights, interests and aspirations of the Naga people.

IIT Hyderabad launches nuclear technology orientation programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

IIT Hyderabad on Tuesday announced the launch of Nuclear Technology Orientation Programme in collaboration with Crismon Energy Experts Pvt Ltd, describing it as a significant step towards strengthening the country's nuclear energy talent pipeline.

The programme, which will commence on August 3 at the IITH campus, is a three-month residential programme designed to equip Engineers and Professionals with a comprehensive understanding of nuclear power technologies and operations and build skilled workforce for India's growing nuclear energy sector, a release from IIT Hyderabad said.

As India accelerates its clean energy transition and expands its nuclear power capacity, the demand for trained professionals with domain knowledge in nuclear technologies is expected to grow significantly, it said.

The Nuclear Technology Orientation Programme (NTOP) aims to bridge this industry-academia gap by offering participants exposure to the technical, operational, safety, and regulatory aspects of nuclear power generation, it said.

The programme is targeted at early and mid-career Engineers, Managers from EPC companies, engineering consultants, power sector personnel, and executives from public sector undertakings engaged in energy and infrastructure development.

The curriculum combines foundational nuclear engineering concepts with practical industry perspectives and covers topics such as Reactor Physics, Reactor Engineering, Radiation shielding, Nuclear safety, Waste management, Reactor instrumentation and Control systems, Thermal hydraulics, Quality assurance, Emergency preparedness, and Advanced Nuclear technologies, including Small Modular Reactors (SMRs).

Participants will learn from IIT Hyderabad faculty and experienced scientists and engineers from the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) organisations, the release said.

Speaking on the launch of the programme, IITH Director Professor BS Murty said that through this programme, IITH aims to contribute to capacity building by bringing together academic expertise and industry experience to develop a highly skilled workforce for strategic sectors.

Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Yatra hits 50 lakh till June, surge 27%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Yatra has achieved a significant milestone in the current calendar year, with the number of pilgrims paying obeisance at the revered cave shrine in Jammu and Kashmir's Reasi district crossing the 50-lakh mark on June 22.

This represents an impressive increase of over 27.3 per cent compared to the 39.84 lakh pilgrims who visited the shrine during the corresponding period last year, an official said on Tuesday.

"During the same period in 2025, approximately 39.84 lakh pilgrims had visited the holy Shrine, whereas the Yatra during the current year has recorded 50.70



lakh pilgrims, reflecting a substantial increase of 10.86 lakh devotees," a spokesperson of the Shrine Board said.

He said the remarkable growth in pilgrim footfall is a testimony to the unwavering faith and devotion of pilgrims from across the country and abroad towards the revered shrine.

"The sustained increase in the number of pilgrims also reflects the confidence reposed by devotees in the arrangements made by the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board and the coordinated efforts of all stakeholders associated with the management of the Yatra," the spokesperson said.

Under the chairmanship of Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, the Shrine Board has undertaken

extensive measures to facilitate a smooth, safe and comfortable pilgrimage experience for devotees.

"Continuous improvements in infrastructure, accommodation facilities, sanitation, crowd management systems, healthcare services, battery car operations, ropeway services, disaster management preparedness and digital initiatives have significantly enhanced pilgrim convenience and overall service delivery," he said.

The spokesperson said the crossing of the 50-lakh mark at this stage of the year is indicative of the growing enthusiasm among devotees and augurs well for the continued progress of the Yatra during the remaining months of the year.





Editor's
TAKE

A country still failing its fire safety test yet again

The Lucknow and Delhi fires are not isolated disasters but symptoms of a deeper governance failure turning negligence into a national hazard

Fourteen young people, most of them students and staff at a coaching-cum-gaming centre in Lucknow's Aliganj, died on June 22 when fire tore through the building they were working in. The visuals were chillingly familiar: panicked youngsters jumping from windows, fire tenders struggling through narrow lanes, a chief minister cutting short his tour to visit the dead. It had happened before – barely three weeks earlier, in Delhi, where 21 people, many of them foreign nationals who had come to the city seeking medical treatment, burned to death in a guesthouse with no valid fire safety certificate. Two cities, two tragedies, one unchanged answer to the question of why: India has still not learned to keep its buildings from killing the people inside them. The two fires look different on the surface – a gaming zone and coaching institute in one city, a budget hotel in another – but strip away the location and the post-mortem is identical. A commercial activity was running inside a structure never built, inspected, or certified for it. A narrow staircase was often the only way out. Combustible material – foam seating, plastic partitions, electronics, bedding – fed the flames once they started. And nobody in the chain of approval seems to have asked whether the building could empty itself in an emergency. That is the real culprit, and it is not one person. It is a system that treats fire safety as paperwork rather than physics. Municipal bodies issue occupancy and trade licenses without verifying clearances from the fire department; fire departments, chronically short-staffed, cannot audit even a fraction of the buildings under their charge; owners convert residential and storage spaces into hotels, coaching centres, and gaming arcades because the rent is higher than the cost of compliance; and enforcement, when it happens at all, follows the fire rather than precedes it.

In Delhi, a cook has been arrested and a case has been registered against unnamed persons – a formulation that conveniently keeps the officials who cleared or ignored the building's status out of the dock. Lucknow's probe has barely begun, but the script rarely changes: a few low-level arrests, a compensation cheque, a promise of audits, and silence once the cameras leave. This is not India's first warning. Uphaar Cinema in 1997, the Surat tuition-centre fire in 2019, the Anaj Mandi factory blaze that same year, hospital fires since – each produced the same commissions, the same recommendations, and the same inertia. Fire safety byelaws already exist on paper.

What is missing is the political will to make violating them costlier than complying with them, and the administrative capacity to actually check.What would change this is unglamorous but specific: independent, surprise fire audits instead of self-certification by owners; criminal liability that reaches the municipal and fire officials who sign off on unsafe buildings, not only the staff on the ground; a public, searchable database of which commercial buildings hold a valid fire clearance; and prosecutions fast enough that cases don't quietly die in years of litigation. Until that changes, the next fire is not a possibility – it is a certainty waiting for an address. The only question is which city's name fills the headline next.

The India-Israel-Iran conundrum

As West Asia enters a new phase of volatility, India's priority must be safeguarding its territorial integrity, ensuring energy security, protecting sea lanes, and strengthening defence capabilities. In that calculus, alignment with Israel while maintaining working transaction relations with Iran better serves India's long-term national interest



PRASHANT
TEWARI

The current turbulence in West Asia has revived an old debate in New Delhi's strategic circles: where should India's long-term interests lie when tensions sharpen between Iran and Israel? While India has traditionally pursued a policy of balance, there are compelling arguments rooted in history, geopolitics, security cooperation, and strategic alignment that suggest India's interests today align more closely with Israel than with Iran. India's civilisational links with Persia are deep and culturally significant. Yet history also carries harsher episodes. The 18th-century invasion of India by Nadir Shah culminated in the sack of Delhi in 1739, leaving scars that entered India's historical memory. While modern Iran is not defined by that episode, it remains a reminder that geopolitical alignments are shaped by power realities, not sentiment.

In the post-independence era, India has fought multiple wars with Pakistan in 1948, 1965, 1971, and during the 1999 Kargil conflict. Throughout these crises, Iran's posture has often been cautious or ambiguously sympathetic toward Pakistan, particularly in the context of Muslim solidarity. In contrast, Israel has steadily deepened security ties with India since full diplomatic relations were established in 1992. India and Israel share converging security concerns: terrorism, cross-border militancy, and hostile non-state actors. Israel emerged as a key defence supplier to India, especially during moments of urgency. During the Kargil conflict, Israel reportedly expedited surveillance drones and precision-guided munitions to India. Over time, cooperation expanded into missile defence systems, border surveillance technology, counter-terror training, and cyber security. Iran's leadership especially Supreme Leader late Ali Khamenei has in the past criticized India's policies in Kashmir on humanitarian grounds. In speeches over the last decade, Khamenei has linked the plight of Kashmiri Muslims with other Muslim-majority regions and said the world should support their rights, framing it in moral and religious terms, though not always calling directly for political support or intervention against India.

The personal rapport between Indian and Israeli leaderships notably between Narendra Modi and Benjamin Netanyahu has further elevated the partnership to a strategic level. Today, Israel is among India's top defence partners, alongside the Russia, United States and France. Intelligence sharing and homeland security cooperation have strengthened India's counter-terror capabilities, particularly in Kashmir and along sensitive borders. Iran's Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei, has on mul-



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The writer is a
public policy expert
and columnist

eighty and refrained from commenting on internal constitutional decisions, including the abrogation of Article 370. In diplomacy, strategic partnerships are often measured not merely by shared interests but by mutual respect for each other's red lines. It is this distinction that continues to shape India's complex balancing act between Israel and Iran. Iran has historically been an important energy supplier to India. However, India's energy basket is diversified, including major imports from Saudi Arabia, Iraq, the UAE, the United States, and Russia. Sanctions on Iran have already reduced India's oil imports from Tehran in recent years. Meanwhile, Israel offers high-technology cooperation in sectors that are central to India's future growth agriculture technology, water management, artificial intelligence, cyber security, and defence innovation. These partnerships are less vulnerable to sanctions politics and align with India's aspiration to become a technology-driven power. India's foreign policy doctrine has long emphasized strategic autonomy. Supporting Israel does not necessarily mean abandoning ties with Iran. India has invested in Iran's Chabahar Port as a gateway to Afghanistan and Central Asia, balancing its continental ambitions against maritime constraints.

However, in a scenario where regional polarisation intensifies, India must assess where its core national interests are most secure. Israel has demonstrated operational reliability in defence cooperation and diplomatic alignment in multilateral forums. Iran, by contrast, remains constrained by sanctions, regional proxy conflicts, and an ideological foreign policy that occasionally intersects uncomfortably with Pakistan's positions.Both India and Israel face threats from radical extremist networks. Cooperation in intelligence, surveillance technology, and counter-insurgency doctrine has been mutually reinforcing. Israel's experience in border fencing, UAV technology, and missile defence has tangible applications for India's national security. In contrast, Iran's strategic engagement with groups across the Middle East including proxy militias reflects a security doctrine that India cannot endorse. New Delhi's interest lies in stability, open sea lanes, and counter-terror coordination, not in proxy-driven escalation. India's foreign policy must remain pragmatic, not emotional.

While civilisational ties with Iran endure and should be preserved, contemporary strategic realities suggest that Israel has been the more consistent and reliable partner in matters central to India's sovereignty and security. As West Asia enters a new phase of volatility, India's priority must be safeguarding its territorial integrity, ensuring energy security, protecting sea lanes, and strengthening defence capabilities. In that calculus, alignment with Israel while maintaining working transaction relations with Iran better serves India's long-term national interest.

Beyond the numbers: The spiritual secret of ageing well



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

I am invited to attend social functions occasionally, which I turn down due to the fact that I tire easily at my age. Such refusals are met with this saying, but I am not convinced, because my experience is different. My advanced age does make a difference to my physical energy level, but I manage my personal tasks and gentle walks after meals quite well.

Surely, I had to know God's plan to check if what I was experiencing was not unusual. What is God's plan for us? A human body has been designed for longevity, that is hundred years subject to two conditions. The first one has to be appropriateness of all what we do, that is eating, activities, 'vihar' (entertainment) and sleeping. (The Bhagavad-Gita 6.17) The other condition is to connect with God from childhood itself. This part we do quite well by



teaching children to pray in schools. Where do we go wrong? In the passion of youth, God is forgotten, whereas prayers for guidance and help are necessary to succeed in life. 'Ahankar' (false ego) comes in the way in middle age when need for God is greater. This results in miseries with advancing age, if not earlier.

This explains why masses suffer. Inappropriate behaviour harms the human body. Add to it bad karmaphalas brought from previous lives. Life is of shorter duration and has many sicknesses. Age is just a number has a different meaning; one has aged prematurely. Don't we see people unable to do even their duties? Some people suffer from laziness.

Contrast this with a minority, who are physically quite active in spite of old age. They give support to the saying

that age is just a number. What is the secret of this utter contradiction between the masses and a small percentage? It is 'jeevani shakti' (vital life force), which is due to good karmaphalas brought from previous lives. The second is appropriate behaviour (6.17), and third is 'kripa' (mercy) of God, who is the source of jeevani shakti. Devotees are beneficiaries of God's kripa, which explains their aura and mental fitness. Even physically they manage quite well. Don't we need more mental power than physical strength in old age? I have a close relative, who has entered the hundredth year, and is quite fit; he is a sincere devotee of God.

The purpose of this article is to alert readers to not get swayed by the saying: age is just a number. For masses, one doesn't even have enough energy expected in different ages, and specially mental in advanced age. Therefore, be very appropriate in everything you do, as instructed by Lord Krishna in the verse # 6.17. Take shelter of God very actively, definitely by the time going past fifty. God will actively help to meet all challenges as they come due to bad karmaphalas. (18.58) He will also give divine jeevani shakti, which will keep the mind, intelligence and body physically and mentally active even in advanced age. Then and then only, age is just a number will have positive meaning.

The writer is spiritual teacher

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CONGRESS WARNS AGAINST 'ONE-SIDED' INDIA-US TRADE DEAL

With US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer arriving in India for crucial trade negotiations, the Congress on Tuesday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi not to be "bambooed" into signing what it described as a one-sided agreement heavily favouring the United States.

The opposition party accused the government of appeasing President Donald Trump and warned that the proposed pact could prove disastrous for Indian farmers and domestic industries while offering little certainty in return.

Congress said there was no need to rush into an agreement that failed to adequately protect national interests.

It recalled that an earlier understanding envisaged the US lowering tariffs on Indian exports from 25 per cent to 18 per cent,

while India would slash duties on several American agricultural and industrial products and substantially increase imports from the US.The party noted that the basis of the arrangement was weakened after the US Supreme Court questioned the legality of President Trump's reciprocal tariff policy.

It alleged that Washington was using ongoing trade investigations to pressure New Delhi into finalising a deal. Congress warned that farmers in Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Maharashtra could suffer if American farm products gained easier access to the Indian market. Indeed the Government must safeguard the interest of our farmers and should not succumb to any pressure

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Glass towers, invisible walls

Sanjay Chandra's piece "The invisible boundaries we build" holds a mirror to urban India's uncomfortable truth. Our cities boast glass towers and gated ease, yet social prejudice quietly thrives behind biometric gates.

The incidents he cites — expecting to regulate a domestic worker's job choice, barring them from resident lifts, or tainting women with their husbands' records — expose how economic progress has outpaced moral progress. Education and success have not erased assumptions about status, belonging, or whose dignity counts.

Physical distance may have shrunk in gated complexes, but social distance often remains intact. We share elevators, parks, and postal codes, yet withhold equal respect. True progress isn't measured by square-foot rates or salaries, but by our capacity to see the humanity in those who serve, support, and sustain our daily lives.

Invisible boundaries persist because they are rarely named. Dismantling them demands introspection, not infrastructure. RWAs must codify non-discriminatory policies, residents must challenge biased remarks, and we must judge individuals on merit, not address or uniform. Urban India's real test is building communities where lifts, laws, and laughter are truly shared. Only mutual respect can make modern spaces inclusive.

VAITHIANATHAN SUBRAMANIAN | MADURAI

Lucknow fire incident was waiting to happen

The fire at a coaching-cum-animation centre in Lucknow, which claimed 15 lives, was a disaster waiting to happen. Investigations revealed that the building had only one staircase and a biometric access system that allegedly hampered evacuation.

Rescue teams reportedly took nearly an hour to breach a side wall, initially using sledge hammers instead of pneumatic equipment.

Most victims died not of burns but due to asphyxiation caused by toxic smoke trapped inside the poorly ventilated structure. The building reportedly lacked mandatory fire clearances, alarms and emergency exits, yet continued operating because of regulatory negligence. Similar unsafe coaching centres and private hostels continue to function across the country, particularly in northern India, where students often live in cramped, poorly ventilated and unhygienic accommodations with inadequate escape routes.

Despite earlier tragedies in Surat, Delhi and Rajkot, little has changed. Nationwide safety audits, strict licensing and zero-tolerance enforcement are urgently needed. It is high time some concrete actions are taken and guilty punished so that such horrific incidents do not repeat.

R.S. NARULA | PATIALA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Lionel Messi gifts himself a new record

Ahead of turning 39 today, it is a perfect birthday gift to himself for Lionel Messi when he set a new record, reaching 18 career world cup goals by scoring twice in Argentina's 2-0 win over Austria at Dallas stadium, Texas.

In the process, the soccer magician surpassed Germany's Miroslav Klose to stand alone at the top of the scoring chart in world cups.

Messi's record-setting goals against Austria carry special weight because they did not come as an isolated statistical moment, but in a match in which Argentina had to play a top-quality game and needed to confirm its smooth progress.

The expanded format means an additional knockout round, a larger number of potential opponents and less room for error after the group stage games.

Argentina's coach Scaloni, therefore, will have to find a balance between relying on Messi's form and integrating other attacking options, especially because the quality of opponents will increase as the tournament continues.

Nevertheless, at the end of the match in Dallas, the message was clear: Argentina has gone through, and at 39 today, Messi remained the player who turns the biggest matches into his own history.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Roots of change: How e-governance is transforming Grameen Bharat

With nearly 900 million people living in rural India, the effectiveness of our Panchayati Raj Institutions will shape the trajectory of the nation's development. A developed Panchayat is not merely a component of a developed India—it is the bedrock upon which a Viksit Bharat will be built.



S P SINGH BAGHEL

Some moments do more than mark a milestone, they illuminate a journey. The selection of four Panchayati Raj initiatives for the prestigious National Awards for e-Governance 2026 is one such moment, a moment that belongs not to any single office, but to every Gram Panchayat and citizen who has placed their faith in a digitally empowered rural India. Inspired by the vision of Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi, India's Panchayats are writing a new chapter of trust, technology and transformation.

As we mark twelve transformative years of good governance under Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, this recognition is a fitting milestone, reflecting how Panchayati Raj Institutions have grown from mere implementing arms of schemes into confident, capable, technologically agile institutions of the third tier of governance.

The National Awards for e-Governance, instituted by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances, represent the highest national benchmark for excellence in technology enabled service delivery. Of 17 projects honoured across 7 categories this year, 4 belong to the Panchayati Raj sector, the natural outcome of twelve years of investment in an enabling environment for grassroots innovation.

The Panchayat Advancement Index, flagship instrument of the Ministry of Panchayati Raj for measuring Gram Panchayat performance, has received the Gold Award for Digital Transformation through Data Analytics. Before it was conceived, there was no standardised, data driven framework to assess the performance of over 2.5 lakh Gram Panchayats. Today, it creates a transparent feedback loop connecting data, performance, recognition, and community participation.

Equally heartening is the recognition secured directly by two Gram Panchayats. Kadepur Gram Panchayat, Sangli district, Maharashtra, won the Gold Award for Grassroots Level Initiatives, having built a digital ecosystem delivering over 1,300 services online through artificial intelligence and blockchain. Bijoy Nagar Gram Panchayat, West Tripura, won the Silver Award, with own source revenue up nearly 194 per cent and full digital literacy among its women. Nandurbar Zilla Parishad's Health Department secured the Gold Award for District Level Initiatives through e-Aarogya Dhamni, strengthening access to quality healthcare services for tribal communities in remote areas.

Together, these awards tell us something significant. Excellence in e-governance is no longer confined to State capitals or district headquarters; it now resides equally in our villages and Gram Sabhas. Over 1.65 lakh Gram Panchayats from 30 States participat-

PRIME MINISTER SHRI NARENDRA MODI HAS CONSISTENTLY EMPHASISED THAT GOOD GOVERNANCE IS GOVERNANCE THAT MAKES LIFE EASIER FOR CITIZENS. EASE OF LIVING, ACHIEVED THROUGH TRANSPARENT, TECHNOLOGY ENABLED SYSTEMS, IS THE TRUEST MEASURE OF A GOVERNMENT'S INTENT AND CAPABILITY.

Prof. SP Singh Baghel is Union Minister of State for Panchayati Raj

ed this year, reflecting the institutional confidence we have nurtured together.

This did not happen by chance. Over the past twelve years, the Ministry has steadily equipped Panchayats with better tools. The e-GramSwaraj platform has digitised planning, budgeting, and payments for over 2.59 lakh Panchayats, enabling online transactions worth more than ₹3.16 lakh crore through the Public Financial Management System. SabhaSaar, powered by artificial intelligence in 23 Indian languages, prepares Gram Sabha minutes within minutes for over 1.35 lakh Panchayats. The Meri Panchayat App, downloaded over 1 crore times, places development information in citizens' hands.

Alongside these strides, the SVAMITVA Scheme has completed drone surveys across 3.30 lakh villages and prepared 3.19 crore Property Cards for 1.94 lakh villages by mid-June 2026, strengthening property rights and credit access for rural families. Under the Fifteenth Finance Commission, grants worth 72.82 lakh crore, the highest ever release percentage, were released to Rural Local Bodies. The Sixteenth Finance Commission has now recommended ₹4.35 lakh crore for 2026 to 2031, an increase of nearly 84 per cent.

To carry this vision further, the Ministry has launched a series of Regional Workshops on Service Delivery titled 'Seva Se Samridhhi: Panchayat-led Service Delivery', bringing together Panchayat representatives, district officials, and domain experts to deepen citizen centric delivery in health, education, livelihoods, infrastructure, to name a few. By showcasing successful local models and enabling peer learning across States, they carry this vision directly to the grassroots. The potential for replication is immense, and Panchayats across the country are increasingly aspiring to adopt these models, drawing inspiration from one another and from institutions recognised at NAEg 2026, to deliver prosperity through service in their own villages.

Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi has consistently emphasised that good governance is governance that makes life easier for citizens. Ease of Living, achieved through transparent, technology enabled systems, is the truest measure of a government's intent and capability. It is a universal truth that to honour others is, in turn, to be honoured. By empowering Panchayats with digital tools and trusting their capacity to deliver, the Central Government has paved the way for the nation to be recognised on this important platform.

As India looks ahead to Viksit Bharat by 2047, the role of empowered Panchayats becomes more central. With nearly 90 crore citizens in rural India, the strength of our Panchayati Raj Institutions will determine the pace of our collective progress. Viksit Panchayat is not separate from Viksit Bharat, it is its very foundation.

These four awards are markers of momentum, an encouragement to every Sarpanch, Panchayat Secretary, and woman representative working at the grassroots, that their efforts are seen and celebrated. Twelve years of consistent efforts have created the enabling environment for such excellence to emerge. From the recognition earned at NAEg 2026 to the growing momentum of Seva Se Samridhhi workshops across the country, this success reaffirms that e-governance has truly taken root in Grameen Bharat, and that the journey of Viksit Panchayat building Viksit Bharat continues to gather strength with every passing year.

The export of skill, the risk of scarcity



SURESH PRABHU | SHOBHIT MATHUR

A Russian construction firm trains Indian recruits on-site to fit glass and aluminum because it cannot find enough workers at home. A Japanese care-home operator flies six Indian nurses to Osaka for nine months of language instruction before letting them near a patient. An Israeli builder, stripped of the Palestinian workforce he relied on for decades, tells officials he needs "close to 100,000" Indian workers to restart construction. These are not isolated anecdotes. They are data points in one of the most consequential and under-appreciated labour-market shifts of the decade.

The structural story is demographic, and it is not subtle. Rich countries are ageing faster than their training systems can replace blue-collar workers. In 2023, 75% of EU firms reported difficulty filling skilled roles. Germany faces an annual gap of roughly 200,000 construction workers. Japan projects a shortfall of 570,000 care workers by 2040. Russia, bled by war and out-migration, needs 789,000 more construction workers by 2030 and, according to its own Higher School of Economics, may require over 12 million foreign workers by 2032. Across all these economies, the common denominator is the same missing person: a trained tradesman who does not exist locally.

India exists as the answer. Its working-age population is enormous, its wages are globally competitive, and it already has deep institutional muscle memory for labour migration, built over five decades of sending workers to the Gulf. What is new is the direction of travel. Workers are now heading to Warsaw, Tokyo, Tel Aviv, and Moscow, not merely to Riyadh and Dubai. The numbers validate this shift starkly. In 2021 Russia issued roughly 5,000 work permits to Indians. By 2025 that figure had reached 72,000, nearly one-third of Russia's entire migrant-worker quota. Italy, via its 2026 Flow Decree, has approved nearly 500,000 work permits for 2026-28 targeting construction, agriculture, and hospitality. Japan has signalled plans to recruit 50,000 skilled Indians over five years. India's Ministry of External Affairs has signed mobility agreements with at least ten countries since 2024, including Germany, Italy, France, Japan, Denmark, the UK, and Taiwan.

Here is where the triumphalist reading breaks down. India's own economy needs the same workers the world is recruiting away from it. The construction and real-estate sector alone is projected to require 30 million additional workers by 2030, including 10.5 million skilled tradespeople. Delhi, Mumbai, and Bangalore are building housing, metros, and data parks at a pace that would absorb every available mason and electrician domestically. Knight Frank's analysis suggests that at current trajectories, urban infrastructure projects are already facing delays for want of skilled labour. And a Canadian analysis cited in the underlying data warns bluntly that within five years, India itself could "face shortages of plumbers, electricians, and carpenters as richer countries aggressively recruit the workers they no longer have."

This is the paradox India's policymakers have not yet named clearly enough to address. The country sits at the centre of a global labour arbitrage that benefits its workers and its foreign-exchange account, while simultaneously eating into the skilled-trades base that its own Viksit Bharat ambitions depend on. The \$135 billion remittance line is both evidence of success and a signal of structural risk.

The mechanism is straightforward. Wages in Japan or Germany for a trained caregiver or electrician are multiples of prevailing Indian rates. For individual workers, the rational choice is obvious. Training institutions, sensing the premium, will increasingly orient graduates toward export. In a country where vocational education has long been stigmatised relative to white-collar degrees, any market signal that dignifies trades work is welcome. But if the signal flows only outward, India is left with a pipeline that trains workers for others.

India's draft Overseas Workers Bill proposes insurance and grievance mechanisms. It addresses symptoms. The deeper need is a managed labour export framework before flows outrun any governance structure entirely.

Three steps matter. First, extend emigration data infrastructure to non-ECR destinations and make data-sharing a standard clause in every bilateral mobility agreement. The current tracking gap is a national blind spot on a market generating tens of billions in foreign exchange. Second, treat skills training for export as industrial policy. If Germany needs 200,000 construction workers a year and India can supply them, that is a sovereign revenue stream worth engineering with curriculum standards, language certification, and sector-specific pathways. Third, India needs a domestic trades reservation policy.

Some share of trained tradespeople must be priced or incentivised to stay. Subsidised wages for domestic projects, fast-tracked certification for returning migrants, and retention quotas for vocational institutes are all instruments worth reaching for. No rich country depletes its skilled workforce without constraint. India need not either. The global demand for Indian blue-collar labour is structural, not cyclical. It will intensify as the demographics of wealthy nations worsen and India's training system expands. The question is whether it represents India capturing a strategic advantage, or India liquidating one.



Suresh Prabhu is a former union minister and parliamentarian. Shobhit Mathur is the co-founder and vice-chancellor of Rishihood University

From risk to resilience: Lessons from India's devastating second COVID wave



NTISH DOGRA

Five years later, the summer of 2021 still evokes a distinct and unsettling memory. There was an eerie feeling, a growing sense that something unprecedented was unfolding, even before its full scale became apparent. This was very different from the first wave. Cases were rising rapidly, but so too was the severity of illness. Hospitals were filling at an alarming pace, oxygen demand was escalating, and mortality was increasing across the country. In terms of deaths occurring over such a short time span, the only comparable event was the tragedy of Partition.

The first indications of the impending crisis emerged through discussions within disaster-response and public-health networks. What initially appeared to be concerns about oxygen availability soon revealed itself as a much broader systems challenge. It became increasingly clear that the crisis would not be defined by a shortage of a single resource, but by cascading failures across interconnected systems, that is, oxygen supplies, ambulances, hospital beds, referral pathways, healthcare personnel, and eventually even funeral services. One enduring lesson from that period is that pandemics are fundamentally systems crises. Failure rarely occurs at a single point; it spreads rapidly

across interconnected sectors.

As the situation deteriorated, another reality became apparent. Given the looming oxygen shortages and mounting pressure on hospitals, the safest strategy for many people was simply not to become infected. There was a growing awareness that once healthcare systems became overwhelmed, avoiding exposure might be the only protection available to thousands of individuals. Yet there was also a profound sense of helplessness. The warning signs were visible, but there were limited mechanisms to communicate the urgency of the situation or translate risk into behavioural change. The experience highlighted a central challenge of crisis management: early warning is useful only if it leads to timely action.

By end April, the anticipated pressures had become reality. Hospitals were operating beyond capacity, healthcare workers were exhausted, and information systems struggled to keep pace with rapidly evolving events. Operational realities were often visible long before they appeared in official statistics. The experience reinforced a fundamental emergency-management principle: decision-makers cannot wait for



perfect information during fast-moving crises. Data almost always lags behind events, requiring action under conditions of uncertainty.

During this period, a virtual incident command system supported by the European Union brought together a small group of experts to help locate hospital beds, connect patients with healthcare providers, facilitate referrals, and support evacuation planning when local systems became overwhelmed. The experience demonstrated the value of incident-command principles even in virtual settings. Shared situational awareness, clear communication, defined responsibilities, and rapid coordination proved essential in managing complexity under extraordinary pressure.

An even greater gap existed at the community level. Thousands of families were attempting to manage illness at home without clear guidance regarding who required hospital care, who could be safely monitored, and when escalation was necessary. In response, a group of medical college alumni collaborated to develop simple, evidence-based home-triage guidelines to help families assess severity, identify warning signs, and make informed decisions regarding care-seeking.

These guidelines were disseminated widely through professional and community networks. The experience underscored a critical lesson in public health emergency management: effective triage begins in the community, long

before a patient reaches a hospital. Empowering families with clear, accessible guidance can be as important as expanding hospital capacity in reducing avoidable morbidity and mortality during health crises.

One image from that period remains permanently etched in memory: the aerial photograph of countless funeral pyres burning through the night. It conveyed the magnitude of loss more powerfully than any epidemiological curve or mortality statistic ever could. Behind every pyre was a family confronting grief and uncertainty. Across the country, children were orphaned, spouses widowed, and communities scarred by loss. It was a reminder that pandemics are ultimately human crises, measured not only in numbers but in lives and futures irrevocably altered.

Today as the world confronts Ebola and Hantavirus these lessons remain highly relevant. Future pandemics may differ in their epidemiology, but the principles of crisis management remain constant: anticipate cascading failures, communicate risk early, establish incident-command structures, implement triage across the continuum of care, support community decision-making, and build resilience before it is needed. The next pandemic may be years away, or it may already be emerging. The challenge is to ensure that the lessons learned at such tremendous human cost in 2021 are not forgotten.

The author is an ICRC and WHO trained disaster management specialist associated with the Pahle India Foundation.

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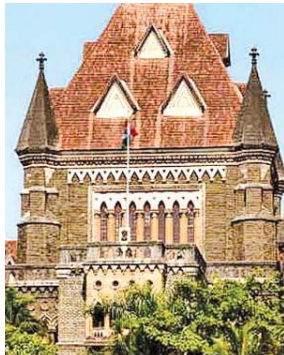
MRMC recommends separate High Court for State



The Mizoram Resource Mobilisation Committee (MRMC) on Tuesday battled for the establishment of a separate high court for the state, noting it would be a significant step in fulfilling the Mizoram Peace Accord provisions and make justice more accessible. Mizoram is under the jurisdiction of the Gauhati High Court. The recommendation was made during a MRMC meeting chaired by Chief Minister Lalduhoma. At the meeting, the members reviewed a range of administrative and fiscal reform measures aimed at improving governance, reducing expenditure, and strengthening resource mobilisation in the state, an official said. According to the committee, the proposal for setting up a separate high court had been recommended by the MRMC Sub-Committee on Administrative Reforms in 2025. (PTI)

Bombay HC questions Govt data on water scarcity

In a blunt observation, the Bombay High Court on Tuesday said the reports submitted by the Maharashtra government about the supply of potable water to villages across the state were false, and the ground reality was different. A day before, the bench of Justices A S Gadkari and Kamal Khata had expressed concern over the water scarcity, especially in the tribal belt of Melghat in Amravati district, and asked the government to submit its policies on the supply of drinking water to such areas. The court was hearing petitions over the issue of deaths of infants, pregnant and lactating mothers due to malnutrition in Melghat. The petitioners had informed the bench earlier that amid soaring summer temperatures, the area was severely affected due to a shortage of clean and potable water, and 13 persons had died due to the consumption of contaminated water.



On Tuesday, additional government pleader Pooja Joshi informed the bench that water tankers were being provided to all villages in the state periodically. The court, however, noted that villages in Amravati district were not getting adequate clean and drinking water supply, due to which several persons there had fallen ill or died. "If the Government is saying water is being provided, then why are such incidents occurring? Your reports are false. They are clearly prepared by officers sitting here in their office. The ground reality is different," the HC said. (PTI)

Anticipatory bail power must be used sparingly: Delhi Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rejecting a plea seeking pre-arrest bail in an alleged investment fraud, a Delhi court has said that the power to grant anticipatory bail is an extraordinary remedy and is to be exercised sparingly.

Vacation Judge Sugandha Aggarwal was hearing the anticipatory bail plea of accused Anand Tiwari, against whom the Special Cell of Delhi Police had registered an FIR. In an order dated June 18, the court said, "The power to grant anticipatory bail is an extraordinary remedy and is to be exercised sparingly."



"The allegations in the present case pertain to an investment fraud involving a huge amount whereby the complainant was induced to part with his hard-earned money of ₹50 lakh." It said, according to the



Justice must remain a human endeavour: CJJ

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said on Tuesday that the administration of justice must remain fundamentally a human endeavour and though artificial intelligence may assist judges, it cannot determine outcomes or exercise judicial discretion.

Delivering an address during his meeting with Igor Krasnov, Chairman of the Supreme Court of the Russian Federation, at Moscow, the CJJ said if technology enhances the capabilities of courts, it is investment in people that determines how effectively those capabilities are utilised. He said institutions may evolve, technologies may change and new challenges may emerge, but the funda-

mental purpose of courts remains to uphold justice in a manner that commands public trust.

"Yet, even as we embrace innovation, we remain acutely conscious of its limits. The administration of justice is, and must remain, fundamentally a human endeavour," the CJJ said.

He said AI may assist judges by organising information, facilitating translations, generating transcripts and streamlining administrative processes, but "it cannot determine outcomes, assess witness credibility, evaluate evidence or exercise judicial discretion".

The CJJ asserted that this distinction is reflected in the draft regulations for the use of AI in the judiciary, recently notified by the Supreme Court,



CJJ Surya Kant during an MoU exchange between the Supreme Court of India and the Supreme Court of Russia in Russia

PTI

which seeks to ensure responsible deployment of AI while preserving judicial independence and human oversight.

He said the supreme courts of India and the Russian Federation serve societies of immense scale and diversity.

Gujarat: AAP MLA Vasava, eight others get 7 years for assaulting forest officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Rajpipla (Gujarat)

A Sessions court on Tuesday sentenced Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) MLA Chaitar Vasava, his wife and seven others to seven years' imprisonment in a November 2023 case of assaulting forest officials and extortion.

Additional sessions judge A V Hirpara also imposed a fine of Rs 25,000 on each of them, Government lawyer Vandana Bhatt said.

The accused included four women, including Shakuntala Vasava, the MLA's wife. As per the prosecution, the incident



AAP MLA Chaitar Vasava

took place on October 30, 2023. Forest officials removed a cotton crop cultivated on illegally occupied government land, which led to a

dispute. The officials were then called to Vasava's residence at Dediapada in Narmada district to discuss the issue.

At his residence, Vasava, a tribal leader who represents Dediapada (ST) assembly constituency, threatened the officials, slapped one of them, and fired in the air from a pistol. The accused, including Vasava's wife, extorted a total of ₹60,000 from forest officials for removing the crop, and Vasava later destroyed the evidence by concealing or disposing of the pistol, the police said.

Vasava's personal assistant, Jitendra Vasava, was accused of contacting the MLA over the phone and asking him to come to collect the extortion money.



TN Government moves SC over Thirupparankundram lamp order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Tamil Nadu Government has moved the Supreme Court challenging the Madras High Court order allowing the lighting of a lamp on the Thirupparankundram hill in the State.

The C Joseph Vijay-led State Government had moved the apex court on June 11 and filed the petition through the Tamil Nadu Government counsel B Karunakaran.

The counsel confirmed the filing of the petition challenging the January 6 order of the Madurai bench of the Madras High Court, which upheld the single judge's order of December 1, 2025, which had ordered that the ceremonial lamp be lit on the festival day.

On January 6, the high court, while upholding the single judge's order, said the apprehension about law and order due to this religious practice is nothing but an "imaginary ghost" created by them for the sake of their convenience. It had made clear that

the spot on which the stone pillar (Deepathoon) is located belongs to the Sri Subramania Swamy Temple and that the Waqf Board, as of date, has no locus in this matter.

"It is ridiculous and hard to believe the fear of the mighty State that by allowing representatives of the Devasthanam to light the lamp at the stone pillar near the top of the hill located within its territory of Devasthanam land, on a particular day in a year, will cause disturbance to public peace," the high court had stated.

"Of course, it may happen only if such a disturbance is sponsored by the State itself. We pray no State should stoop to that level to achieve their political agenda," the high court order had said.

The case arose from a writ petition of one Rama Ravikumar and others seeking directions to light the sacred Deepam at the ancient stone pillar on Thirupparankundram hill during the annual Karthigai Deepam festival in November-December.

Use of forged documents before court cannot be viewed lightly: Supreme Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said offences involving forgery and the use of forged documents in judicial proceedings are serious in nature and cannot be viewed lightly.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and NV Anjaria observed while modifying the sentence of five years given to a man for using a forged revenue document for furnishing surety in judicial proceedings.

"There can be no manner of doubt that offences involving forgery and use of forged documents in judicial proceedings are serious in nature. Sections 467 (Forgery), 468 (Forgery for cheating) and 471 (using a forged document) of the Indian Penal Code deal with the offences which undermine the authenticity and sanctity attached to public and legal documents. Use of forged documents



before a Court of law cannot be viewed lightly," the bench said.

The top court said while considering the question of sentence, the court is required to balance the nature of the offence with the attendant facts and circumstances of the case, the role attributed to the accused, the period of incarceration undergone, the passage

of time and other mitigating circumstances relevant to sentencing jurisprudence. "The principle of proportionality remains central to the sentencing process. Sentencing cannot be reduced to a purely retributive exercise divorced from the factual matrix of the case and the overall circumstances of the offender," the bench said.

The apex court said in this case, the occurrence pertained to the year 2014, and the man has remained under the shadow of criminal proceedings for more than a decade. "No material has been placed before this Court indicating that the appellant is a habitual offender or that he was involved in similar criminal activity either before or after the present occurrence," it said.

The top court said the present case is not one involving organised criminal activity, large-scale economic fraud, systematic forgery affecting public institutions or recurring acts of deception causing widespread financial loss.

Surat court allows withdrawal of 2018 case against Hardik Patel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Surat

A Surat court on Tuesday allowed the withdrawal of a case of unlawful assembly filed against Gujarat BJP MLA Hardik Patel and four others that was registered in 2018 during the Patidar reservation agitation spearheaded by the former activist.

The case related to the violation of conditions under which a pro-reservation rally in Surat was permitted by law enforcement authorities.

Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Jitendra Singh accepted the state government's application to withdraw the case against Patel

and four others registered at the Varachha police station in the city, the ruling party MLA's lawyer, Yashwant Vala, said.

As per the FIR, Patel and the other accused, including Alpesh Kathiriyaa, Dharmik Malviya, and Ashok Jirawala, violated the conditions laid down for the event.

Police had permitted them to garland only a statue of Sardar Patel, but they addressed a crowd of supporters gathered on the occasion, thereby obstructing road traffic and violating one of the conditions of the rally.

The police had then registered a case under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) sections



about unlawful assembly, assaulting a public servant and disobedience of a lawful order, among others.

The BJP Government had

issued a notification ordering the withdrawal of nearly 90 per cent of cases related to the Patidar quota agitation, including those under sedition

charges. A Sessions court in Surat in December last year had withdrawn a seditious case against Patel and others.

Patel rose to prominence in 2015 by leading the state-wide Patidar reservation agitation, which demanded Other Backward Class (OBC) status for the Patidar community in Gujarat.

In 2019, he joined the Opposition Congress and a year later was appointed the working president of the party's state unit.

The 33-year-old switched sides and crossed over to the ruling BJP in 2022, and the same year, he won the state assembly elections from Viramgam in Ahmedabad district.

SC stays Delhi HC order for premature release of 1993 Kolkata Bowbazaar blast case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday stayed the Delhi High Court order directing the premature release of a life term convict in the 1993 Kolkata Bowbazaar blast case.

A bench comprising Justices PK Mishra and Sanjeev Sachdeva gave the interim relief on a plea filed by the West Bengal government, challenging the June 5 order of the high court directing the forthwith release of the 77-year-old convict, Md Rashid Khan.

notice to Khan, who was convicted under the stringent provisions of TADA, on the plea of the State Government.

Appearing for the state government, additional solicitor general SV Raju said the high court erred in its finding and questioned relying on reformative theory for granting relief to Khan in a case where more than 70 people died, and hundreds got injured in the bomb blasts.

Senior advocate MR Shamsad, appearing for Khan, submitted that he had spent over 33 years in prison, and highlighted that a co-accused, Pannalal Jaiswara,

was granted remission in March 2014.

The bench, however, said the roles attributed to them were completely different while pointing out that Khan was the "mastermind" of the incident.

Shamsad submitted that the conduct of the prisoner, which has been good in prison, should be taken into account.

The bench observed that he was sentenced for an act which was "almost a terrorist act." Khan's counsel highlighted his poor health condition and told the bench, "He is not mentally incapac-



itated, but he is in bad condition." The bench said if the high court's order is not stayed, the State's appeal will become infructuous.

The State Government has contended that the high court granted the relief despite the recommendation made by the State's Sentence Review Board (SRB) against his release, as Khan was convicted under the Terrorist and Disruptive Acts Prevention Act (TADA).

On June 5, the high court took into account Khan's long period of incarceration, prison conduct and the reformative philosophy and ordered his

premature release. A special TADA court in 2001 had convicted Khan and four others in the 1993 Bowbazaar case, which occurred at his workshop, where explosives were stored. Khan was sentenced to life imprisonment under TADA, the Arms Act and the IPC.

The top court later upheld the convictions. While allowing his release plea, the high court set aside the State SRB's decision communicated through an order dated August 8, 2018, which had rejected his request for premature release.



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Ujin Pharma files IPO papers with SEBI to raise funds



Chemical products supplier Ujin Pharma has filed preliminary papers with capital markets regulator SEBI to raise funds through an Initial Public Offering (IPO) in a move to expand its supply chain and chemical processing footprint.

The proposed IPO is a combination of a fresh issue of 1.18 crore shares along with an Offer for Sale (OFS) of 72.82 lakh shares by promoters – Jinesh Rasiklal Sheth and Umang Ketan Mehta, according to the Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) filed on Monday.

Of the proceeds from the fresh issue, the Mumbai-based Ujin Pharma plans to use ₹61.7 crore and ₹21.6 crore to invest in its associate firms – Altra Agro-Chem and Altra Pharma-Chem – respectively, by subscribing to equity shares and thereby making them subsidiaries.

Additionally, ₹25 crore will be utilised for debt payment, and a portion would be used for general corporate purposes.

Ujin Pharma is primarily engaged in distributing and supplying a diversified portfolio of solvents, speciality chemicals, acids, pharmaceutical raw materials and nutraceuticals.

Its distribution business involves sourcing chemical products from domestic and international suppliers and supplying them to multiple end-use industries, including pharmaceuticals, agrochemicals, speciality chemicals, industrial and automotive, petrochemicals, paints and coatings, printing inks, and packaging.

SMC Capitals and Marwadi Chandarana Intermediaries Brokers have been appointed as book-running lead managers to assist the company with its public issue. The company's shares will be listed on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and the BSE.

(PTI)

Tech Mahindra widens ties with Telefonica Germany



IT company Tech Mahindra on Tuesday announced expansion of its partnership with Telefonica Germany to build a private cloud platform.

This is aimed at driving cloud-native transformation and provide Platform-as-a-Service (PaaS) for technology and enterprise business growth, Tech Mahindra said in a release. "The partnership will combine Tech Mahindra's platform engineering and AI-first operations with Telefonica Germany's telecom infrastructure modernisation objectives to create PaaS, laying the foundations for a full scale private cloud," the release further said. The multi-year engagement will focus on enabling a scalable, open, and future-ready digital infrastructure foundation to modernise telecom and enterprise workloads, it added.

Tech Mahindra will also leverage AI-driven automation, cloud-native orchestration, infrastructure-as-code frameworks, and self-service platform management capabilities to support the platform as a service.

The platform is designed to enhance AI-first automation, operational flexibility and resilience while supporting both traditional and infrastructure services for telecom and enterprise businesses across Germany.

(PTI)

PSU banks lose gold loan sourcing share as private banks, NBFCs gain traction: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Public sector banks' dominance in gold loan sourcing is gradually facing pressure as private banks and NBFCs gain traction, according to the report.

This is supported by stronger distribution reach, faster turnaround times and changing customer preferences, according to an Experian report titled 'Gold Loans in Transition: Market Evolution & Consumer Patterns'. "The market structure is gradually shifting



toward private and NBFC-led sourcing, highlighting stronger distribution reach, faster turnaround times, and growing customer preference for non-bank lenders in the gold loan segment," the

'India needs to diversify its sources of energy needs'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The West Asia conflict was a short-term supply chain problem, but it has taught that countries like India should diversify the sources of their energy needs, NITI Aayog vice chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri said on Tuesday.

Releasing the Eighth Edition of 'Trade Watch Quarterly', Lahiri further said he is hopeful that soon India and the US will finalise and sign a bilateral trade agreement.

He said the NITI Aayog has also suggested that when India negotiates a free trade agreement with any country or bloc, then it should include a chapter on pharmaceutical products. "So, it is like you have fever, but if it is influenza, you will not be very worried, you know," he said.

"In three days it will get all right, but if you hear that it's typhoid or jaundice, you will be very worried. So, the West Asia crisis has turned out to be influenza," Lahiri said.

The war in West Asia broke out on February 28 when the



NITI Aayog vice chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri

Silver tumbles ₹8,158 to ₹2.26 lakh/kg as dollar rally dents bullion appeal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Silver futures retreated by ₹8,158 to ₹2.26 lakh per kg, tracking weak global trends amid a strong dollar and rising expectations of higher interest rates by the US Federal Reserve.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), the white metal for July delivery slumped by ₹8,158, or 3.48 per cent, to ₹2,26,152 per kilogram in a business turnover of 10,059 lots.

Similarly, the September contract also plunged by ₹8,629, or 3.59 per cent, to ₹2,31,509 per kg in 6,291 lots.

Analysts said bullion sentiment remained under pressure as traders reassessed the outlook for US monetary



policy amid a rally in the dollar and elevated Treasury bond yields.

"Silver prices moved lower in the domestic markets, as a stronger US dollar and rising

expectations of further interest rate hike by the Federal Reserve weighed on investor sentiment," Navneet Damani, Head of Research - Commodities at Motilal

Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

The dollar index is closer to one-year high, following possibility of a Fed rate hike as early as September and elevated Treasury bond yields, he added.

The weakness in domestic markets mirrored a sharp-selloff in the overseas trade.

In the international markets, Comex silver futures for July delivery fell \$3.57, or 5.45 per cent, to \$62.01 per ounce in New York.

"Silver saw a sharper decline in the overseas trade, dropping to \$62 per ounce level as uncertainty surrounding US-Iran peace talks weighed heavily on market sentiment," Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

RBI injects ₹1.41 lakh cr transient liquidity in banking system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday injected ₹1,41,171 crore transient liquidity into the banking system through a seven-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction.

The funds were infused at a cut-off and weighted average rate of 5.26 per cent, according to the RBI's release.

This was done after the liquidity in the banking system turned in to deficit of ₹19,971.89 crore as on June 22, from a surplus of ₹30,685.11 crore as on June 21.

Experts attributed the tightening of liquidity to the outflows on account of goods and services tax (GST) payments from the banking system.

The liquidity entering the deficit territory has put pressure on the overnight



money market rates, with weighted average call money rate trading at 5.43 per cent, which is 0.18 per cent above the RBI's repo rate. Similarly, the tri-party repo (treps) were trading 0.05-0.07 per cent over the repo rate.

In the last few days, the central bank

has been infusing transient liquidity into the banking system as it has come under pressure since outflows of advance tax payments.

To ease liquidity pressures and keep overnight money market rates in check, the central bank has infused transient liquidity of about ₹2.43 lakh crore through variable rate repo (VRR) auctions of different tenures over the past few days.

Of the total infusion, the RBI injected ₹36,300 crore on Monday via overnight VRR, ₹16,750 crore on Friday through three-day VRR auction, ₹72,300 crore on Wednesday through two VRR auctions, ₹89,440 crore via a seven-day VRR auction on June 16, and ₹28,220 crore through an overnight VRR auction on June 15, according to the RBI data.

India's pharma supply chain dependent on Chinese imports, says NITI Aayog

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's pharmaceutical supply chain remains heavily dependent (65 per cent) on Chinese imports for critical active pharmaceutical ingredient (APIs) and key starting materials, NITI Aayog said on Tuesday.

The Aayog, in its eighth edition of 'Trade Watch Quarterly', further said that rising environmental compliance requirements have significantly increased manufacturing and R&D costs in India. "Supply Chain and Sustainability Challenges: India's pharmaceutical supply chain remains heavily dependent on Chinese imports (65 per cent) for critical active pharmaceutical ingredient (APIs), Key Starting Materials (KSMs), and intermediates, particularly fermentation-based products," it said.

The report pointed out that weak innovation and a commercialisation ecosys-



tem have created uncertainty for innovators and long-term investments.

It pitched for promoting diversification into high-value pharmaceutical segments.

The report also called for enhancing regulatory transparency and stronger industry-academia technology transfer in life-sciences clusters to accelerate patent commercialisation, research collaboration, and startup incubation.

Releasing the report, NITI Aayog vice chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri said India is

considered the pharmacy of the world.

"NITI Aayog has found out that while we are doing all right in terms of volume in pharmaceutical sector, we need to move up the value chain," Lahiri said.

He said India has some credibility in the international market, and he does not see any reason why Indian pharmaceutical companies, if they come up with good quality, modestly priced branded products, should not command a high international market.

Tata Motors PV plans capex of up to ₹40k crore in 5 yrs



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd has lined up capex of up to ₹40,000 crore in the next five years as it seeks to garner 20 per cent share in the domestic market by nearly doubling its volumes to over 12 lakh units annually by FY31, according to its investor presentation.

The company plans to launch six new models by FY31 while it aims to have 13 lakh units annual production capacity within two to three years, its Managing Director & CEO, Shailesh

Chandra, said in the presentation.

The domestic passenger vehicle industry is expected to grow to 64 lakh units annually and electric vehicles (EV) volumes are projected to touch 10.11 lakh units annually by FY31, reaching 15-20 per cent EV penetration, he said.

The overall median industry selling price will increase to around ₹15 lakh from ₹11-12 lakh in FY26, Chandra noted.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles (TMPV) has also set an ambition of 30 per cent EV penetration for itself by FY31, with a portfolio of 10 EV models.



SEBI mulls common ad code for market intermediaries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

SEBI on Tuesday proposed allowing market intermediaries, including stock brokers, mutual fund houses, investment advisors and portfolio managers, to engage celebrities for promoting their brands or entity name, while prohibiting endorsements of specific products or services. The proposal is part of a consultation paper on a Common Advertisement Code (CAC) for specified Sebi-regulated entities, aimed at harmonising advertising norms, reducing compliance burdens and strengthening investor protection.

Under the proposed framework, celebrity endorsements would be permitted only at the regulated entity's brand or corporate level, subject to prescribed conditions and

appropriate disclaimers. Celebrities would not be allowed to endorse specific investment products or services offered by such entities. At present, celebrity endorsement is permitted at the industry level in AMC with prior approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI).

The capital market watchdog has also proposed replacing the existing requirement of prior approval for advertisements by stock brokers, Online Bond Platform Providers (OBPPs), investment advisors (IAs) and research analysts (RAs) with a post-issuance reporting mechanism. Advertisements would need to be reported to relevant stock exchange or SEBI-recognised supervisory body within 24 hours of their issuance, after which they would be subject to monitoring.

Foreign investors pour ₹35,000 cr in Indian bonds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Foreign portfolio investors put in around ₹35,000 crore so far this month in Indian bonds after the Government exempted them from income tax on interest income and capital gains arising from investments in these bonds, according to Clearing Corporation of India Ltd (CCIL) data. All these investments came under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) of Indian Government securities.

This is because FAR allows non-resident investors to invest in specified Government of India-dated securities without any investment ceilings, as per data.

FPI holdings in FAR securities stood at ₹3.58 lakh crore on Tuesday, up from ₹3.23 lakh crore on June 3, the data showed. Prior to this, the foreign investors have poured ₹5,512.108 crore in May and ₹5,262.016 crore in April. However, there were outflows of ₹17,687.988 crore in March. The Government on June 5 promulgated an ordinance amending the Income Tax Act to provide tax exemption on interest income and capital gains arising from the sale, exchange or transfer of government securities held by FPIs. The exemption is applicable retrospectively from April 1, 2025.

The move came as the Government looked to attract more foreign capital into the domestic debt market and support the rupee amid external pressures. Currently, foreign investors are subject to a long-term capital gains tax of 12.5 per cent on listed shares and bonds held for more than 12 months, while interest earned on government bonds attracts a withholding tax of 20 per cent.

FROM THE WORLD

LITHUANIA

Prime Minister Inga resigns

Lithuanian Prime Minister Inga Ruginiene and her cabinet stepped down Tuesday after changes to the ruling coalition, setting the stage for the Baltic country's third prime minister in two years and an incoming Government that has pledged to pursue a more pragmatic relationship with China after years of strained ties.

Ruginiene's Government collapsed after the centre-left Social Democrats ended their coalition agreement earlier this month with the scandal-ridden populist Nemuno Ausra party as one of its former leaders faces allegations of antisemitic rhetoric. Remigijus Zemaitytis, a former lawmaker, was fined 5,000 euros last year by a Lithuanian court after it found that he had incited hatred against Jews, grossly downplayed Nazi Germany's crimes and grossly minimized the Holocaust in an offensive and insulting manner in social media posts and public statements from May and June 2023. The case is now with the appeals court as prosecutors ask for a stricter sentence. Zemaitytis has pleaded not guilty.

SAJJAD HUSSAIN

Islamabad

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian arrived in Pakistan on Tuesday on a day-long visit to discuss the full implementation of all clauses of an agreement signed between Iran and the US, as well as regional and international developments of mutual interest.

The Iranian leader landed at Nur Khan airbase, where he was received by President Asif Ali Zardari, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and other high officials, according to state-run PTV. Separately, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi arrived here from Muscat. He had travelled to Muscat along with Parliament Speaker and chief negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf to hold high-level talks with the Omani

leadership to discuss the management of the Strait of Hormuz. The Foreign Office said earlier that President Pezeshkian has been undertaking the "State Visit" at the invitation of Prime Minister Sharif. President Pezeshkian, accompanied by a high-level delegation, arrived in Islamabad aboard a special aircraft "Minab 168" to honour the victims of the US strikes on the country, particularly the 168 students from Minab school who were killed in the American attacks, official media reported.

During his visit, Pezeshkian will meet President Zardari and hold talks with Prime Minister Sharif. Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar, the Senate chairman and the National Assembly Speaker will also meet with him. This is his second visit to Pakistan in his capacity as President of Iran.



Pakistan Prime Minister Office, Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian walking with Pakistan's President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif upon his arrival at Nur Khan airbase in Rawalpindi, Pakistan

Ahead of his departure, the Iranian president said his visit "aims to secure full implementation of the memorandum under international law". He added that the agreement would help strengthen stability and security

in West Asia, state-run Press TV reported.

In a post on X, Pezeshkian cautioned that "the effectiveness of the talks depends on full commitment to the agreed obligations and their precise implementation."

"Progress on this path will be measured by practical adherence to accepted responsibilities. Statements outside the agreed text do not help advance the negotiations," he added. During the visit, the two sides will review the full

spectrum of bilateral relations and explore new avenues to deepen cooperation across diverse sectors, including trade, energy, border security, people-to-people exchanges, and regional connectivity, the Foreign Office said. The visit will also provide an important opportunity to discuss ongoing diplomatic engagements following the signing of the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, as well as regional and international developments of mutual interest, it added.

His visit comes after Iran held talks with the US in Switzerland, where the two sides agreed on a roadmap to seal a final deal in 60 days.

The high-level talks at the Lake Lucerne Summit in Switzerland, held on Sunday and Monday, took place under the framework of the

Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed by the US and Iran on Thursday to advance negotiations on regional security and other contentious issues.

Security was on high alert in Islamabad due to the Iranian leader's visit. The Government closed bus terminals in the capital to restrict the movement of people coming to the city. The Red Zone has been closed.

Even the Islamabad High Court and the Federal Constitutional Court postponed the hearing of cases as both courts are in the high-security Red Zone, where visitors are not allowed today.

The US and Iran signed the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Thursday to restore peace in West Asia, advance negotiations on regional security and other contentious issues. (PTI)

Imperative for India and China to respect each other's core interests: FM Wang

KJM VARMA

Beijing

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi has said that it is "imperative" for India and China to respect each other's "core interests" and take concrete actions to implement the "important consensus" reached by the leaders of both countries.

Wang, who is in New Delhi to attend the BRICS NSA conference, made the remarks during his meeting with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval on Monday, according to China's state-run Xinhua news agency.

During their meeting, Wang and Doval discussed the bilateral relations and progress of the normalisation process. Both Wang and

Doval are the Special Representatives of the India-China border issue.

India is an important neighbour of China, and bilateral relations have returned to the track of recovery and improvement, said Wang, who is also a member of the Political Bureau of the ruling Communist Party of China and director of the Office of the Central Commission for Foreign Affairs.

Wang noted that the leaders of the two countries agreed that China and India are partners instead of rivals, thus forming the most important strategic consensus between the two sides, providing an important impetus and strategic guarantee for the healthy and stable devel-



Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi

opment of China-India relations, according to an official press release issued here on Monday night on the Doval-Wang meeting.

As the two economies with the largest populations, China and India should not only view bilateral relations from a long-term perspective, but also promote cooperation between the two countries from a global perspective, Wang said. He noted that both sides should take concrete actions to implement the important consensus reached by the leaders of the two countries, promote their respective development and revitalisation through cooperation, and accelerate the modernisation process of the Global South. It is imperative to respect

each other's core interests, properly handle sensitive issues, and place the China-India border issue in an appropriate position, so that it doesn't affect the overall situation of bilateral relations, Wang said.

He also underlined the need to advance the restoration of dialogue mechanisms and promote exchanges in various fields, such as trade, finance, law enforcement and media, Xinhua reported, quoting the official press release. The two sides should also actively guide all sectors of society to form a correct understanding, and lay a solid public opinion and social foundation for improving bilateral relations, Wang added. Responding to a question on Doval-Wang talks,

Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told media here on Tuesday that the China-India border area is generally stable and the two sides maintain open communication channels on border-related issues.

"Both sides are actively implementing the common understandings reached in the 24th Round of Talks Between the Special Representatives of China and India on the Boundary Question, and are working hard in preparation for the 25th round of talks," he said.

In New Delhi, External Affairs Ministry spokesman Randhir Jaiswal on Monday said that the Doval-Wang discussions were "constructive and forward-looking". (PTI)

Form No. URC-2

Advertisement giving notice about registration under Part I of Chapter XXI (Pursuant to section 374(b) of the companies Act, 2013 and rule 4(1) of the companies (Authorised to Register) Rules, 2014)

1. Notice is hereby given that in pursuance of sub-section (2) of section 366 of the Companies Act, 2013, an application has been made to the Registrar at ROC- Delhi & Haryana that **NO FIXED ADDRESS** a partnership firm -a business entity may be registered under Part I of Chapter XXI of the Companies Act 2013, as a company limited by shares

2. The principal objects of the company are as follows:
Travel agency activities, Activities of travel agents and tour operators.

3. A copy of the draft memorandum and articles of association of the proposed company may be inspected at the office at Property No H. NO. 6-A, FIRST FLOOR, KH. NO. 858, CLUB DRIVE ROAD, VILL GHITORNI, NEW DELHI, DELHI-110030.

4. Notice is hereby given that any person objecting to this application may communicate their objection in writing to the Registrar at 4th Floor, IFCI Tower, 61, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019, within twentyone days from the date of publication of this notice, with a copy to the company at its registered office.

Name of the Applicant :-
NO FIXED ADDRESS
Dated this 24th day of June 2026

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector - 6, Noida - 201301 (U.P.)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on NOIDA Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <http://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

(A)

1. 17/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance & Strengthening of Electrical works for different offices (Electrical-I to IV, Horticulture-I to III, Work Circle-4,8,9 offices, SM (Jal)-III office, SPO office & Mahila Thana) in Sector-39, Noida. Cost Rs. 32.02 Lacs.

2. 19/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of High mast in Different Sectors-1,2,3,4,5,6,7,22,23,24,25,25A & Vill-Chaura Raghunathpur, Noida. Cost Rs. 42.88 Lacs.

3. 20/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of Community Center, (Authority Building) at Sec-19,20,27,55,56,66,68 Vill-Garhi Chaukhandi, Noida. Cost Rs. 39.28 Lacs.

4. 21/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of Electrical works in Staff Quarter Type-I, II, III & IV in Sector-5, 6, 10, 19, 34, 20, 24, 25, 30, 31, 33, 35, 39, 40, 55, 56, 62, 66, 82, 93, Noida. Cost Rs. 46.28 Lacs.

5. 25/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of Window Split type Air-Conditioner Installed in Various Courts at Noida Stadium, Sector-21A, Noida. Cost Rs. 64.76 Lacs.

6. 26/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Electrical Maintenance of Sport Complex Building in Noida Stadium Sector-21A (Squash, gym, Badminton, Table Tennis etc.), Noida. Cost Rs. 53.83 Lacs.

7. 27/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of Street light, Park Light, High Mast light in Noida Stadium, Sector-21A, NOIDA. Cost Rs. 54.43 Lacs.

8. 28/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Supply and Installation of Decorative Pole for Beautification in Noida Stadium Sector-21A, Noida. Cost Rs. 80.45 Lacs.

9. 29/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Annual Maintenance of High mast in Different Sectors-62,63,63A, 64,65, 69, Rajat Vihar & Vill-Basai Noida. Cost Rs. 68.21 Lacs.

10. 30/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Strengthening of Street light at Main roads in Sector-12 & Between road of Sector-11 & 12, Noida. Cost Rs. 73.80 Lacs.

11. 51/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M- III/26-27, Providing Decorative Pole & High Mast on Internal road of F & G Block sector-44, Noida. Cost Rs. 47.74 Lacs.

12. 52/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M-III/26-27, M/o Authority Building (Internal Electrification work for Community center in Sector-15), NOIDA. Cost Rs. 37.53 Lacs.

13. 53/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M-III/26-27, Strengthening of Park Light pole in Different block of Kanchenjunga apartment, Sector-53, Noida. Cost Rs. 78.92 Lacs.

14. 54/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M- III/26-27, Annual Maintenance of Street Light in sector-39,40,41,46,47,48, Related Road of these sectors and MP-3 road, Noida. Cost Rs. 84.17 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: 07.07.2026 upto 5:00 PM.

Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date:- 08.07.2026 at 11:00 AM.

(B)

1. 08/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T/2026-27, Providing Lighting arrangement in 5%Abadiplot in Sector-141, Noida. Cost Rs. 33.14 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: 30.06.2026 Upto 5:00 PM.

Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: 01.07.2026 at 11:00 AM.

Office Sector-5, Noida

General Manager (E&M) Noida

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

NORTHERN RAILWAY

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice Inviting Application for the appointment of Yatri Ticket Suvidha Kendra (YTSK) over Delhi Division (File No. C6/PRS/YTSK/Policy-III/2026)

1 Notice Inviting Application No.

C6/PRS/YTSK/Policy-III/2026

2 Name of the work

Appointment of Yatri Ticket Suvidha Kendra (YTSK) for issuance of Reserve cum Unreserved tickets through Passenger Reservation System (PRS) cum Unreserved Ticket System (UTS) terminals for a period of three years over Delhi Division.

3 Tender Type

Open Application

4 Address, Last Date & Time for submission of application through Offline mode

Applicants who wish to submit their applications offline may submit their application from 23.06.2026 to 13.07.2026 between 10:00 hrs and 17:00 hrs, and on 14.07.2026 up to 15:00 hrs, at the Commercial Branch, Office of the Divisional Railway Manager, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055

5 E-Mail Address where applicants may submit through Online mode

Applicants who wish to submit his/her application through Online, may submit their applications at the following official e-mail address: srcdm.ndls@gmail.com w.e.f. 23.06.2026 to 14.07.2026 up to 15:00 hrs.

6 Address of website from where complete details of application can be seen

The Application Notice and Application documents are available on the official website of Northern Railway i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in in PDF format.

No: C6/PRS/YTSK/Policy-III/2026 Dated : June '2026

2164/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PRAKASH WOOLLEN & SYNTHETIC MILLS LIMITED

Regd. Office: 18th Km Stone, Delhi Moradabad Road, NH-24, Village Amhera, Distt. Amroha-244102
Tel: 91-9760091983

Website: www.prakashwoollen.com; Email: info@prakashwoollen.com
CIN: L17291UP1979PLC004804

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS

(SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGEMENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES)

Pursuant to SEBI circular no. H0/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSD-P0D/1/3750/2026MIRSD/MIRSD- PoD/P/CIR/2025/97 dated January 30, 2026, the company is pleased to offer one time special window for physical shareholders to submit re-lodgement requests for the transfer of shares. The special window will be open for a period of one year from February 05, 2026 till February 04, 2027 and is applicable to cases where original share transfer requests were lodged prior to April 01, 2019 and were rejected/returned due to deficiency in the documents, process or any other reason. The shares re-lodged for transfer will be processed only in dematerialization mode during this window. Eligible shareholders may submit their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the company's registrar and share transfer agent (RTA) at M/S Skyline Financial Services Private Limited within stipulated period.

By order of the Board of Directors
Prakash Woollen & Synthetic Mills Limited

Place: Vill. Amhera (Amroha)
Date: 23.06.2026

Sd/-
(Vijay Kumar Gupta)
(Whole-Time Director)
DIN:00335325

COSCO (INDIA) LIMITED

CIN : L25199DL1980PLC010173
Regd. Office : 2/8, Roop Nagar, Delhi-110 007
Website : www.cosco.in Email : mail@cosco.in
Tel. : 91-11-23843000 Fax : 91-11-23846000
BSE Trading Symbol: COSCO

NOTICE

Pursuant to the SEBI Circular No: HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSDP0D/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 all shareholders are hereby informed that a Special Window is open from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027, to facilitate re-lodgement of transfer request of physical shares which were rejected, returned or not attended due to deficiencies in documents/process/otherwise.

Shareholders are advised to visit Company website www.cosco.in for SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026
https://www.cosco.in/uploads/investors/sebi_circular_ease_of_doing_investment_special_window_for_transfer_and_dematerialisation_of_physical_securities_1772005272.pdf.

Investors are encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity by furnishing the necessary documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent i.e. Skyline Financial Services Private Limited at Office Add. D-153A| 1st Floor|Okhla Industrial Area, Phase - I New Delhi-110 020.Email-id: admin@skylinereta.com, Tel No. 011-26812682-83, 40450193 to 97.

This is for your kind information.

For Cosco (India) Limited,
Sd/-
Sudha Singh
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Place: Delhi Date : 23rd June, 2026
Membership No.: A33371

India, US begin high-level trade talks as two nations rework deal amid tariff changes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

India and the United States opened high-level trade talks on Tuesday aimed at salvaging and recalibrating a proposed bilateral trade agreement after changes in US tariff policy upended a framework negotiated earlier this year.

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal met US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer here as both sides sought to conclude an interim trade pact before July 24, when Washington's temporary 10 per cent tariff on imports from trading partners is due to expire.

"Warm welcome to @USTradeRep Amb Jamieson Greer, @USAmbIndia Amb Sergio Gor and their delegation to @DoC.Gol. Looking forward to productive discussions on the bilateral trade agreement between (India & US)," Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said in a post on X.

Greer's two-day visit comes days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump held their first meeting in more than a year on the sidelines of the G7 summit in France on June 17, injecting fresh momentum into trade negotiations that both sides see as critical to strengthen-

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal during a meeting with a delegation of Safran Aircraft Engines in New Delhi

ing economic ties.

The talks are focused on reworking a framework agreement announced in February that was built around tariff commitments later rendered uncertain by a US Supreme Court ruling striking down sweeping tariffs announced by Trump.

The meeting at Vanijya Bhawan, the headquarters of the commerce ministry, is also being attended by Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal and India's chief negotiator Darpan Jain, sources said.

It follows chief negotiator-level discussions held in New Delhi earlier this month (June 2-4). Securing preferen-

tial tariff treatment has become a central objective for New Delhi after changes in US trade policy eroded an advantage India had expected to enjoy over regional competitors such as Vietnam and other ASEAN economies. Under the February framework, the United States had agreed to reduce tariffs on Indian goods to 18 per cent, lower than duties facing several competing exporters. However, the subsequent court ruling and Washington's decision to impose a temporary 10 per cent tariff on imports from all countries have forced both sides to revisit key ele-

ments of the arrangement. Agrawal on June 15 stated that the discussions between the two sides are expected to be centred around giving final touches to the framework deal.

On June 17, US President Donald Trump said the two countries are "very close" to finalise the trade agreement.

Earlier on June 5, Goyal said India and the US are moving towards closing all open ends of the interim trade agreement, and both sides are likely to execute the "very, very vibrant" first phase of the Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) by the middle of next month.

Armed group in Nigeria kills 20 people

An armed group killed at least 20 people in a community located in the north-central region of Nigeria, police said on Monday. The attack occurred Sunday in the Kawel community located in the Bokkos area of Plateau State, police spokesman Alfred Alabo said in a statement. Police officers quickly arrived at the scene and exchanged gunfire with the assailants, forcing them to retreat, Alabo said. No arrests were reported.

No group immediately claimed responsibility for the attack in a region that has experienced a recurring pattern of violence. "The remains of the victims have since been released to their families for burial, as the families declined autopsy," Alabo said.

कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, अनुरक्षण शाखा (गंगा)
उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, जगजीतपुर, हरिद्वार-249408
ई-मेल - eegangaujs@gmail.com

पत्रांक : 487 / निविदा सूचना / 2026-27 दिनांक - 23.06.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

मुख्य महाप्रबन्धक, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान देहरादून की ओर से कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, अनुरक्षण शाखा, (गंगा) जगजीतपुर हरिद्वार, के अन्तर्गत Providing of Cesspool suction vehicles & supervisors on hiring basis during Kanwar mela-2026 हेतु निम्नानुसार कार्यो के सम्पादन करने हेतु दर अनुबन्ध के लिये ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

क्रो स्रो	कार्य का नाम	घरोहर घनराशि (लाख मे)	कार्य की समाप्ति	बिड सिस्टम	निविदा मूल्य	श्रेणी
1.	Providing of Cesspool Suction Vehicle (cap. 3000 to 5000 liters) at rent for Collection and Transportation of septage generated at Kavar Patri During Kavar Mela-2026 including fuel. Lubricant, Chemical, driver & Sewer Staff including all taxes. 56 Vehicles for 15 Days.=840 No's	247800.00	कांवड मेला 2026 के दौरान	एकल -बिड	4000.00+18% (जी.एस.टी.)	डी0 एवं उच्चतर

Sl. No	Details of Tender Activity	Date Of Activity
1	Date of Tender	24-06-2026
2	Date of online Publication of tender Notice and tender document	27-06-2026 at 17:00 hrs.
3	Online Document download: Start Date	27-06-2026 at 17:00 hrs.
4	Online Document download: End Date	10-07-2026 at 17:00 hrs.
5	Pre Bid Meeting	01-07-2026 at 11:00 hrs.
6	Physical Submission of Bid Security, cost of bid Document and offline Submission of bid Documents: End Date	10-07-2026 at 17:00 hrs.
7	Date of online Technical Bid Opening	11-07-2026 at 11:30 hrs.

ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त जानकारीयों व शर्तों उत्तराखण्ड की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर ऑनलाइन देखी / प्राप्त की जा सकती है।

अधिशासी अभियन्ता
जल संवय-जीवन संवय

Starmer steps down, and Labour is facing a fast reckoning



SURJIT SINGH FLORA

Outside 10 Downing Street, Keir Starmer stared into the cameras and made what some at Westminster had already imagined spoken out loud. He said that he would resign as leader of the Labour Party and remain as the caretaker prime minister until a successor was nominated.

The spirit was dark and sometimes stuttering. Less than two years after getting Labour to a landslide election, Starmer said, he wasn't the right man to lead the party from here to the next general election. The news rippled through Parliament because the fall was so abrupt.

"Every decision I have taken has been about putting the country on which I hold great feeling in mind. It is for this reason that I will resign as leader of the Labour Party."

The speech resolved one immediate question as to his future, but it left open a much darker one concerning the course of Labour. Starmer's collapse can seem sudden, but the warnings were all along. Labour took 411 seats and a majority of 174 – its third biggest Commons haul after Tony Blair's triumphs in 1997 and 2001 – in July 2024. But the scale of that victory masked a vulnerable public base. Labour received just 34 per cent of

the vote. That gap mattered. A big majority gave Starmer plenty of freedom as a governor, but also of course not long-term loyalty from voters or patience from the MPs. Labour's support faltered soon after public services crumbled and living costs remained high.

Ipsos counted the damage hard. One year into serving, Starmer's average net satisfaction fell to minus 66, the worst score the pollster had ever measured for any prime minister since 1977. More immediate statistics still see him at minus 60 for the recent period, 76 percent unhappy and just 16 percent positive.

Starmer had had to step into office after years of Conservative splintering, so he had promised steadiness and control. Instead, his Government became well-known for reversals and internal dissent and a widespread sense that the prime minister had little to no political narrative.

The first major injury was with the decision to limit pensioners' winter fuel allowance. The savings were small, and the anger was big, and the subsequent U-turn deepened that sense of drift. Then, in October of 2024, came Rachel Reeves's budget, which faced criticism for increasing the tax rate to help already squeezed families.

The trouble then spread up through the party. In the summer of 2025, as a rebel backbench uprising assembled strength Starmer had to relax planned



cuts to disability benefits. After concessions, 49 Labour MPs voted against the Government.

Senior ministers, including Shabana Mahmood and Yvette Cooper, privately pressed him to establish a timetable for his departure. Wes Streeting left the cabinet on May 14 and left leaving the crisis visible, not contained.

University of Strathclyde Professor John Curtice explained the problem in simple words. Starmer, he said, never articulated what he believed in or how he meant to run the country. For many Labour MPs that erosion of trust proved deadly.

Pressure on Starmer became increasingly so once Andy Burnham returned into the

picture. Burnham had appeal beyond Westminster, and unlike most critics inside the House of Commons, he presented himself as a credible successor.

He was first seeking to return to the Commons. Starmer initially blocked his move from Manchester mayor to a by-election, and he relented. Burnham won Makerfield with more than 50 percent of the vote, overtaking Reform UK and Restore Britain with that much more to offer.

That outcome changed the mood. Private frustration turned public pressure, given MPs now a rallying point. Burnham's return made Starmer's position hard to justify to a lot of Labour members on the edge of losing seats to

Reform at the next election.

Labour has acted swiftly to avoid a protracted vacuum at the top. The party has outlined a short contest that runs from July and is likely to end before Parliament returns from summer recess. The timetable is important because Labour cannot afford months of drift. Markets, civil servants and foreign partners can engage with a caretaker, but without a settled leader – who always seems to be someone who isn't going away – a ruling party tends to make an inward turn. The main name in the race appears, however, as Burnham. And his Makerfield win gave him momentum, while his public persona matches the vibe of a party with the aspiration to have a more prominent voice and clear political instincts.

Wes Streeting is the other important player still, though outside the cabinet. He may, or may not, run – or he might shape the race through his backing. In any case, his act matters because it speaks to the part of Labour – which has not abandoned its vision of reform in the light of its failure to move beyond Starmer's years.

Other older executives may be kept out and play a part in shaping the outcome. The importance and influence of endorsements, group deals, and who will be able to calm the parliamentary party won't matter less than speeches. Starmer stays in

Downing Street but his grip has been compressed much more sharply. He can still direct cabinet, carry on day-to-day Government business and go to international meetings while the contest is ongoing. What he cannot accomplish is recover authority within Labour. Any substantial domestic shift would have no political effect, and any reshuffle would appear to be temporary. He is in office but only until the party decides what to go ahead with.

The promise of competence, and the reality of collapse

Starmer had risen because of a simple promise. He appeared methodical and careful and serious as a former director of public prosecutions. That image helped Labour look safe again after the turmoil of the Conservative years.

Government revealed the limits of that style. A caution gave way into hesitation. Discipline became second nature to repeated revolts. The rhetoric to end chaos sounded empty as ministers resigned, policies changed under duress, and awkward calls, such as the Peter Mandelson ambassadorial appointment, bred doubts about judgment.

Starmer exits power with a baffling record. He secured a massive Commons majority, then failed to turn it into lasting support. Even opponents considered him to be decent and hard-working, but he ended up the

most unpopular prime minister in modern Ipsos polling.

Labour must now determine what it is for, and not just who it will run its base around. That search has arrived amid a period when Reform is coming harder on the right and public patience with the two big parties has become short-lived.

Should a new Labour leader take power, before autumn, Britain would have had its seventh prime minister in a decade, a cruel snapshot of just how unstable the country's politics have become in a decade of being a very unstable one. Starmer's resignation brings a brief, painful period of Labour's political struggle to an end.

Starmer's step down as party leader, his tenure as caretaker prime minister followed up by leaving the party and a compressed race through July through late summer.

The underlying story is more difficult for Labour to escape. A leader elected by competence lost authority among voters, then with MPs, and then with his own cabinet.

The race after each vote is about more than succession, because it will determine whether Labour will be able to regain the purpose it lost nearly as soon as it acquired power.

(The writer is a veteran journalist and freelance writer based in Brampton, Canada)

Andy Burnham eyed as Britain's next Prime Minister

JILL LAWLESS ■ London

Andy Burnham, Britain's newest lawmaker and likely its next prime minister, was meeting Labour colleagues on Tuesday in preparation for a leadership contest in which he may be the only contender.

Burnham is the strong front-runner to replace Prime Minister Keir Starmer, who announced on Monday that he will step down within weeks after two years in office marred by missteps and judgment errors that eroded his standing with party and public.

Burnham, a former Cabinet minister who served since 2017 as mayor of Greater Manchester, won a special election last week for a seat in Parliament with the express aim of challenging Starmer for the leadership.

Burnham's chances got a big boost on Monday when former Health Secretary Wes Streeting, who was considered his main rival, announced his support.

Britain's parliamentary



Andy Burnham with colleagues from the Parliamentary Labour Party in Westminster Hall at the Houses of Parliament in central London, as he returns to the House of Commons to take up his seat after winning the Makerfield by-election

system allows governing parties to change leaders – without the need for a national election. The next general election does not have to be held until 2029. Nominations for the Labour leadership will open

July 9 and close a week later. If Burnham is the only contender, he could be prime minister by July 17. If there is a contest, the winner should be in place by the time Parliament returns from its summer break on Sept 1.

Burnham's economic plans are not yet known

Burnham was a popular mayor of Manchester, overseeing a period of rapid regeneration for the city where the Industrial Revolution was forged, and has pledged to repeat his signature brand of "Manchesterism" on a national scale. Many Labour members hope Burnham's people skills and charisma can connect with the public more than the stolid, managerial Starmer could ever do. But his policies in many areas are unknown and untested. Some Labour lawmakers want to see a party election contest where he would face public debate and scrutiny.

Burnham is expected to make a speech next week outlining some of his economic plans.

Former Armed Forces Minister Al Carns, who quit this month to protest what he saw as inadequate defence spending, said "we need to have a clear and concise discussion about what this country wants to be." He has suggested he might run for the leadership but told broadcaster ITV that "I'm not ready to make a decision on this in any way, shape or form."

Others have suggested Darren Jones, a senior Cabinet minister and Starmer ally, should run, though he has yet to commit.

Potential candidates need the support of at least 81 Labour lawmakers, a fifth of the parliamentary party, to run. Many argue that a leadership contest will only focus attention on the party's internal divisions and extend a period of political uncertainty.

"I think the transition should be swift and orderly," Cabinet Office Minister Nick Thomas-Symonds told the BBC.

Shooting at California library kills 2: Police

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Chico

A shooting at a library in Northern California left two people dead and a suspect is in custody, according to police.

Police responded to a 911 call soon after 5 pm Monday in which the sounds of gun shots and people screaming could be heard coming from inside the Chico branch of the Butte County Library, Billy Aldridge, the city's chief of police, said during a news conference.

Once officers were inside the library, the suspect fled out of the back, he said. Additional law enforcement behind the library took the suspect into custody, according to Aldridge.

"The incident this evening was obviously very sad, traumatic for a lot of people. Very traumatic for our community," he said. The streets around the library were closed temporarily and a family reunification center



was set up for the people who were inside the building.

A child was also taken to the hospital with a minor injury. Aldridge said there is no serious threat to the public and law enforcement are investigating the shooting. The police didn't release the suspect's name nor details on what prompted the shooting. Law enforcement said they believe the shooter acted alone.

Law enforcement are also not releasing the names of the people killed until next of kin have been notified. The county urged the public to avoid the area and said all Butte County library branches will be closed Tuesday.

NATO summit: Turkey detains 200 in Ankara raids

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ankara

Security forces in the Turkish capital carried out sweeping raids on Tuesday ahead of next month's NATO summit, and detained more than 200 people with suspected links to extremist groups, including the Islamic State group.

US President Donald Trump is expected to join other leaders of the 32-member alliance in Ankara for the July 7-8 summit.

Turkey is planning strict security measures for the summit, including banning demonstrations and restricting access to roads leading to airports, as well as sealing off areas around the summit venue and hotels hosting delegations. The Government of



Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan has prioritised security and authorities regularly carry out security raids. Last month, security

prosecutors issued detention orders for 241 suspects, and 209 of them were subsequently taken into custody in police and gendarmerie raids around Ankara, according to a statement from the chief prosecutor's office.

The raids were still underway later Tuesday to take in the rest of the suspects. Among those detained were 56 alleged Islamic State militants and 35 members of the Revolutionary People's Liberation Party/Front, a far-left group known for armed attacks and assassinations in Turkey. The Islamic State group has also carried out numerous deadly attacks in Turkey, including the 2017 New Year's Eve shooting at an Istanbul nightclub that killed 39 people.

Taliban to hold rare, closed-door talks with EU officials on deportations

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Brussels

A delegation from the Afghan Taliban is traveling to Brussels on Tuesday for closed-door talks with European Union staff, expected to focus on deportations, said a Taliban official. Afghans make up one of the largest groups of migrants seeking asylum in the European Union, but a growing number of Governments in the 27-nation bloc want to speed up and increase deportations for those whose claims are rejected or who commit crimes in their host countries.

Afghan authorities have imposed draconian restrictions on rights, particularly for women and girls, since the Taliban seized power in the country in 2021 in the wake of the chaotic withdrawal of US-led forces.

Rights groups said Tuesday's meeting undercuts the EU's human rights obligations and could endanger people in Europe and Afghanistan. "Any engagement with the Taliban needs to prioritize protecting human



rights and accountability – not deporting people to danger there," said Fereshta Abbasi, a researcher at Human Rights Watch. "EU countries are undermining their credibility by condemning Taliban abuses and pursuing accountability on one hand, while cooperating with the Taliban to forcibly return Afghans on the other."

The five-person delegation in Brussels from the Taliban – a Government that none of 27 EU nations recognizes – includes Abdul , a New Zealand-born spokesperson for the Taliban's foreign ministry, said a Taliban official speaking on condition of anonymity.

Man arrested for stealing cemetery body parts in Hungary

JUSTIN SPIKE ■ Budapest

Police in Hungary have arrested a 30-year-old man who investigators say collected human body parts that he'd gathered from abandoned cemeteries and from his workplace at a hospital.

Hungary's National Bureau of Investigation arrested the man in Budapest on June 17 after receiving information that he'd been storing the body parts at work and at home. The man is employed as an orderly at a hospital, police said in a statement on Tuesday.

During a search of the man's apartment, investigators seized skulls, a complete lower leg and a hand, as well as a reconstruction of a human face prepared from facial skin. Other bones were found stored in a suitcase.

A heart in a jar was also found, which police were trying to determine whether it was of human or animal origin. The man, who admitted collecting the body parts during questioning, said that he was particularly attracted to human body parts, and that he had prepared food from such parts and eaten them. (AP)



Bangladesh Police arrest Awami League activists marking anniversary despite ban

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Dozens of activists of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina's now-disbanded Awami League party were arrested overnight as they staged sporadic street marches to mark the party's 77th founding anniversary in defiance of a nationwide security ban, authorities said on Tuesday.

Founded on June 23, 1949, when present-day Bangladesh was East Pakistan, the Awami League is the country's oldest political party and led the nation's 1971 Liberation War. The party was disbanded by the



Muhammad Yunus-led interim Government after Hasina's Government was toppled on August 5, 2024, following a violent student-led street protest dubbed the July Uprising. The move was later endorsed by Parliament under the Government led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman.

Through its social media platforms, the Awami League urged supporters to hold digital discussions, hoist party flags, organise processions and conduct poster campaigns to mark the anniversary.

A police headquarters spokesman said 26 activists of the "banned party" were

arrested in Dhaka alone, while several others were detained in other places in the country for staging processions or attempting to defy the ban amid heightened security.

"We have foiled their plan so far, and I hope that within the remaining time, they will not be able to bring out a procession, hold a rally or gather anywhere," Dhaka Metropolitan Police (DMP) Commissioner Mosleh Uddin Ahmed told a media briefing. The DMP, later in a statement, said that legal proceedings against those arrested were underway and operations would continue to maintain public safety and law and order in the capital.

Despite the restrictions, Awami League social media platforms uploaded video clips showing party leaders and activists holding street marches, carrying party flags and banners and chanting slogans. On the eve of the anniversary, Hasina, in a social media post, said, "We were not born to be defeated." Hasina has been staying in India since her ouster in 2024.

She was sentenced to death in absentia by Bangladesh's International Crimes Tribunal over charges linked to attempts to suppress the student-led agitation.

PROSPECT



Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma chaired a review meeting with the Indian Army, NHIDCL, PWD, and district officials to discuss practical solutions for easing traffic congestion along the Rillong—Anjalee—Bark Point Road

NEGDCL, GAIL sign pact to supply natural gas across Assam's North Bank



For the first time in history, natural gas produced in Upper Assam will be supplied across the North Bank of the State up to Baihata Chariali through the North East Gas Grid, with plans to extend supply to Guwahati and other areas via GAIL (India) Limited's pipeline network. The milestone comes under the Government of Assam's initiative to boost the State's industrial and commercial sector, and under the leadership of Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma and Bolin Chetia, MLA of Sadiya Constituency and Chairman of North East Gas Distribution Company Limited (NEGDCL). The development is expected to bring significant relief to industries and commercial establishments facing challenges from the ongoing LPG crisis. In the initial phase, the supply will cover the districts of Darrang, Udalguri, Sonitpur, Bishwanath, Lakhimpur, and Dhemaji. Industrial and commercial units across these six districts will now have access to cleaner, more reliable, and cheaper domestically produced natural gas. Officials said the move, achieved with the support of the Government of Assam, marks a major step toward making Assam an industry-friendly and environmentally sustainable State. It will also support the Government of India's efforts to reduce dependence on imported LPG and conserve foreign exchange reserves. Marking the development, NEGDCL Chief Executive Officer Manuj Kumar Baruah signed a Gas Sale Agreement (GSA) with GAIL (India) Limited for the supply of domestically produced natural gas to industries and commercial establishments in the above-mentioned districts.

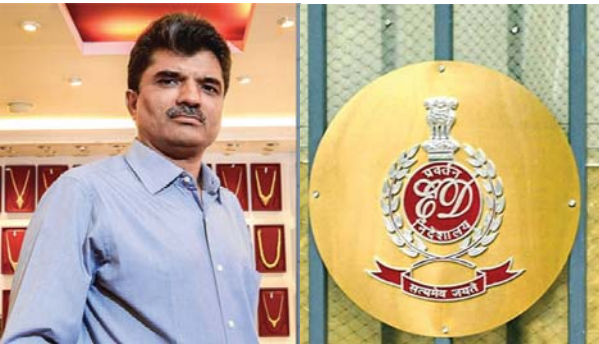
ED raids Rajesh Exports after SEBI findings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru / Mumbai

Weeks after the SEBI findings of an inflated invoice of more than ₹15 lakh crore, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday conducted searches against Rajesh Exports. The case is registered under FEMA (Foreign Exchange Management Act) after finding a huge foreign fund inflow and outflow to Rajesh Exports' linked firms operating in foreign countries.

The ED raids are happening at Bengaluru and Mumbai, said officials. Rajesh Exports Ltd allegedly inflated its consolidated revenues by more than ₹15 lakh crore over five years by attributing massive revenues to overseas subsidiaries, particularly Switzerland-based Valcambi SA, despite the subsidiary's audited standalone financial statements showing only a fraction of those amounts, according to an interim order by SEBI.

According to investigators, Rajesh Mehta headed firm had siphoned the majority of the funds from India to



Rajesh Mehta

Switzerland-based Valcambi SA, a gold refinery unit. This refinery is believed to be owned by Rajesh Mehta.

The regulator has restrained the company's Chairman and Managing Director, Rajesh Mehta, from buying, selling or dealing in securities of Rajesh Exports, either directly or indirectly, until further orders. As per a detailed analysis of the TransUnion CIBIL data filed by Canara Bank, Rajesh Exports owes a total of ₹2,458 crore, and the loan amount is split into six entries of ₹409 crore each. Canara Bank is now conducting recovery suits at the Debt Recovery Tribunal

(DRT) in Chennai, and three directors of the company are shown as personal guarantors to these loans. The directors shown as personal guarantors are Rajesh Mehta and his partners, Prashant Mehta and S Paramasivan.

Rajesh Exports has also filed a counter case in DRT against the bank, seeking loss of more than ₹20,456 crore. However, DRT in 2023 dismissed the company's claim, citing that they produced fake bills. The 2023 order observes that Rajesh Exports diverted funds from Canara Bank through its subsidiary gold refinery, Valcambi SA in Switzerland.

Army Chief honours Assam veteran Colonel Dibya Shankar Bhattacharya

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Chief of Army Staff (COAS), General Upendra Dwivedi, honoured a distinguished military veteran from Assam, Colonel Dibya Shankar Bhattacharya (Retd), with a Chief of Army Staff Commendation Card and Medal at an official ceremony held in Tezpur on Saturday.

While presenting the award, the Army Chief lauded Col Bhattacharya's dedicated service to the Nation and highlighted his exemplary contributions both during and after his distinguished military career. General Dwivedi remarked that even after retirement, Col Bhattacharya has continued to embody the highest ideals of duty, commitment, integrity, and professional excellence.

The Army Chief further stated that Col Bhattacharya has made invaluable and unparalleled contributions towards the progress and development of the country. Through his exemplary conduct and selfless service,



he has set a remarkable precedent not only for fellow veterans but also for citizens across the nation.

Col. Dibya Shankar Bhattacharya served the Indian Army with distinction for over 33 years. He holds the unique distinction of being the first individual from Assam to secure an all-India Rank-1 in the UPSC National Defence Academy (NDA) Examination. During his illustrious military career, he served in operational areas along both the Pakistan and Chinese borders and actively participated in Operation Rakshak

counter-insurgency operations in Punjab and Jammu & Kashmir, as well as Operation Parakram.

An outstanding military professional, Col Bhattacharya also achieved the distinction of standing first in the prestigious Senior Officers Course of the Indian Army. Throughout his service, he held several important and prestigious appointments and also served on deputation as a director in the Border Roads Organisation (BRO), where he distinguished himself through exemplary leadership and administrative excellence.

Assam emerges as semiconductor hub: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma highlighted the State's remarkable transformation over the past decade, saying Assam has evolved from being associated with insurgency to emerging as one of India's fastest-growing states and a future semiconductor manufacturing hub.

Delivering the keynote address on 'Man on a Mission' at the Republic Summit 2026 in the national Capital, the Chief Minister said the next two decades would belong to Eastern and North-Eastern India as the region unlocks unprecedented opportunities in industry, trade and innovation in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

"From insurgency to an upcoming semiconductor hub, this is the transformation of Assam over the last decade. Today, we are the



fastest-growing state in India and attracting global attention," he said.

Projecting Assam as India's gateway to Southeast Asia and neighbouring countries, the Chief Minister said the state is leveraging its strategic location, natural resources and improving infrastructure to attract global investments.

"We are the entry point of the country. We have to develop a culture of welcoming industry," he said. Highlighting Assam's

growing industrial ecosystem, Sarma announced that Tata Semiconductor would begin exporting semiconductor chips from Guwahati by November.

"By November, Tata Semiconductor will start exporting chips from Guwahati. We are going to export 48 million chips from Guwahati," he said.

The Chief Minister also noted that Assam's economy is expanding at a pace higher than the national average, reflecting the state's growing

contribution to India's development. Expressing confidence in the region's future, Sarma said Eastern and North-Eastern India possess immense potential to become key drivers of the country's economic growth.

"We have the natural resources, we have the international borders, we have the market. We just have to create an environment for industry, and the next two decades will belong to the East and Northeast," he said.

He urged people to embrace optimism and work collectively towards building a prosperous future.

"We have to bring positivity because we have been deprived so much. Once positivity comes, we will be the bright spot of the economy and contribute to the growth of the nation," he said.

The Chief Minister also underlined the importance of safeguarding India's border regions and ensuring balanced development in frontier states.

PFC raises \$300 million via dollar bonds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned power sector finance company PFC said it has raised \$300 million via issuance of USD-denominated bonds.

In a statement on Monday, Power Finance Corporation (PFC) said it has become the first central public sector undertaking (CPSU) and the first in the NBFC space to successfully tap the international bond market following the announcement of the special swap facility by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) in its latest monetary policy statement.

The \$300-million senior unsecured USD-denominated bonds with a tenor of 5 years are "priced at 105 basis points over the benchmark five-year US Treasury for a fixed coupon of 5.32 per cent per annum", PFC said.

The issue saw a strong investor demand, attracting active and wider participa-

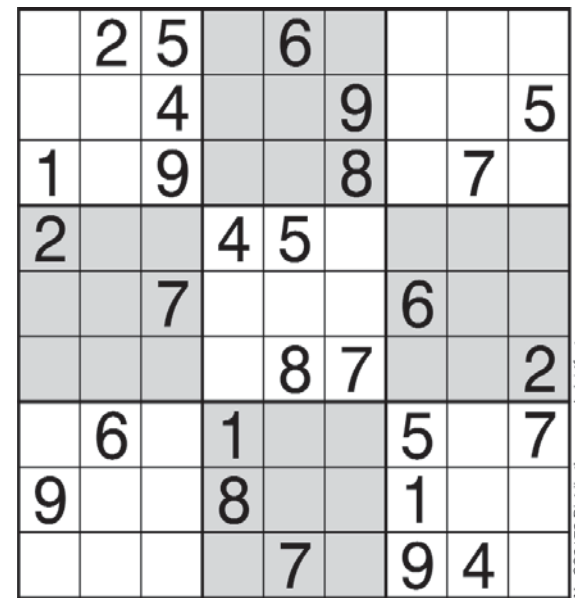


tion from investors across European and Asian markets, the company stated.

"This issuance supports the Government of India's broader objective to attract foreign capital into the country. The deal reflects confidence of investors in PFC's business as well as its credit profile and the growth story of Indian Power sector," said Parminder Chopra, Chairman and Managing Director of PFC.

The proceeds from bonds will be used for on-lending to the power and infrastructure sector and general corporate purposes, PFC said.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

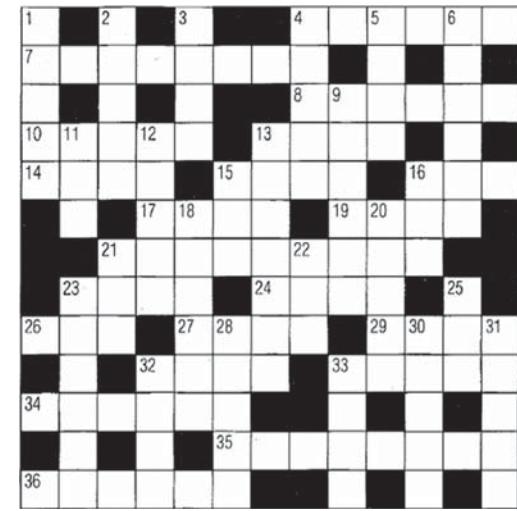
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (23.6.26)								
8	4	2	1	3	6	9	5	7
1	3	6	5	9	7	2	8	4
5	9	7	8	4	2	1	6	3
6	2	3	9	1	5	7	4	8
7	8	9	4	6	3	5	2	1
4	5	1	2	7	8	3	9	6
9	6	8	7	2	1	4	3	5
3	1	4	6	5	9	8	7	2
2	7	5	3	8	4	6	1	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | JUNE 24, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 3 Time will certainly not stand still! (5)
 - 8 Apply for the job of president? (5)
 - 10 To rob thus shows no humanity! (5)
 - 11 The "beat" of a giant heart! (3)
 - 12 Bad ignition (5)
 - 13 Familiar form of grub chewed by diners without much noise (7)
 - 15 In Germany we get faultless service (5)
 - 18 Wherein the chemists could have a little party (3)
 - 19 Possibly sent half a mile to rest in comfort (6)
 - 21 Went back to bed (7)
 - 22 Honest people? (4)
 - 23 Small quantity of margarine returned

- (4) 24 Cabin with space for nautical manoeuvres? (3,4)
- 26 Macbeth's fancied weapon (6)
- 29 Time to finish supper with heavy heart (3)
- 31 Means of locating "12"? (5)
- 32 Vain advice not to consume so much (7)
- 34 Joe, a six-footer, is very big (5)
- 35 Air composed by George Gershwin's brother (3)
- 36 In a state of confusion on the ocean (2,3)
- 37 The stuff comes in a bowser, generally
- 38 Criticise the possibility of a debt on it?

- DOWN**
- 1 Use a knife on some stuff in a cup (3,2)
 - 2 Felt things tailored to make a singlet! (7)
 - 4 They can be put on in the manner of a sari (4)
 - 5 Exulted when, given credit, one was in debt (6)
 - 6 The flat stones shone weirdly! (5)
 - 7 Way to make love by the book (5)
 - 9 Bit of a stare from Jack (3)
 - 12 Rabbit cooked up for the referee (7)
 - 14 One must do so or die in the attempt! (3)
 - 16 Rant or rave about the weather (5)
 - 17 Once more, a manuscript takes plenty of paper (5)
 - 19 Closest to seeming unusually earnest

- (7) 20 Tiger's golf clubs? (5)
- 21 The rule for keeping a guerrilla leader in check (5)
- 23 The keepers can tell you where the land lies (7)
- 24 A broken romance (6)
- 25 Alternatively, sweetheart, it's a mineral (3)
- 27 A rota arranged to play a vital part in circulation (5)
- 28 Pledges made when short of fruit? (5)
- 30 Custom socially acceptable to a wise man (5)
- 32 One you knit soundly? (4)
- 33 Stray from the proper route (3)

- SOLUTION (23.6.26)**
- ACROSS
 - 4, Tot-Ems
 - 7, Pul-lover
 - 8, Is-land
 - 10, Ra-n-ts
 - 13, Pail (gale)
 - 14, Tin-a
 - 15, Palm
 - 16, Are
 - 17, Stan
 - 19, Ogre
 - 21, St-arts out
 - 23, Deer (dear)
 - 24, H-OM-e
 - 26, Ten
 - 27, Trey
 - 29, S-n-ub
 - 32, Pair
 - 33, State
 - 34, M-inor-S
 - 35, Ki-te ma-rk
 - 36, F-risky.
 - DOWN
 - 1, Sport
 - 2, Glenn
 - 3, Toss
 - 4, T-rial
 - 5, Tell
 - 6, Manure
 - 9, Simp-OM
 - 11, Air
 - 12, T-aste
 - 13, Panther
 - 15, Pa-R
 - 16, Art
 - 18, Tar-tar
 - 20, Quest
 - 21, Sen
 - 22, So-y
 - 23, Denier
 - 25, Out
 - 28, (F-)Risky
 - 30, Nat-Al
 - 31, Becky
 - 32, Pots
 - 33, She-m.

Forest Department must lead with integrity, performance and purpose: Jayanta Mallabaruah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Delivering a clear message of reform and accountability, Forest Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah on Monday outlined a new vision for Assam's Forest Department, stressing that integrity, transparency and performance must become the defining pillars of the department's functioning.

Chairing a review meeting of all Territorial Forest Divisions at the Assam Administrative Staff College, Khanapara, the Minister said the department has already earned recognition for its role in protecting forest land and implementing the government's forest encroachment eviction drive. He credited officers and frontline staff for these achievements and urged them to continue safeguarding Assam's natural resources with dedication and professionalism.

In one of the strongest messages delivered during the meeting, the Minister declared that corruption in



THE MINISTER SAID THE DEPARTMENT HAS ALREADY EARNED RECOGNITION FOR ITS ROLE IN PROTECTING FOREST LAND

the name of transfers and postings would not be tolerated under any circumstances. He warned officers, employees and intermediaries against seeking or accepting money by invoking the names of political leaders or senior officials

and assured strict action against anyone found involved in such practices.

A significant portion of the day-long review meeting was devoted to brainstorming on revenue enhancement, identifying systemic bottlenecks, plugging leakages and improving coordination among departments. Emphasising the need for a more result oriented approach, Minister Baruah said the department must focus on unlocking the full potential of Assam's forest resources while maintaining its commitment to conserva-

tion and environmental protection.

He observed that with efficient management, transparency and better enforcement, the department has the potential to multiply its current revenue generation, creating additional resources that could substantially contribute to the state's development priorities, including the establishment of several new medical colleges.

Officials from the Departments of Taxation and Transport also participated in the meeting as part of efforts to formulate a coordinated strategy for improving government revenue through greater interdepartmental collaboration. The Minister concluded by urging all officers and staff to work honestly wherever they are posted, accept transfers as part of service discipline, report corruption without hesitation and uphold the reputation of the Forest Department through integrity, efficiency and public service.

IRFC observes International Day of Yoga

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In line with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to promote yoga as a way of achieving a healthy and balanced life, Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) celebrated the 12th International Day of Yoga.

Organised around this year's theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing," the pro-



gramme included a yoga session in which employees actively participated.

Speaking on the occasion, Manoj Kumar Dubey, Chairman and Managing

Director of IRFC, said that yoga is an important part of India's ancient knowledge tradition and continues to guide people toward a healthy and disciplined life. He said that yoga is not limited to physical fitness but also helps in maintaining mental peace, self-discipline and balance in daily life. Dubey said that yoga helps individuals perform their duties with greater focus and efficiency.

MSTC LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)

NOTICE OF E-AUCTION OF SCRAP

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Please visit our website www.mstcecommerce.com for more details.

BRIEFLY

Black jaguar in Rio sniffs Brazil to beat Scotland



A new animal oracle for the World Cup has arrived, and it's the kind that few would challenge even if its prediction is wrong. A black jaguar named "Poty" has made her pick at Rio de Janeiro's BioParque for the highly anticipated World Cup Group C clash between Brazil and Scotland in Miami on Wednesday.

Residents and soccer fans watched closely on Monday as Poty took part in a lighthearted forecasting event, which placed her in front of two enrichment boxes representing the two rivals. The jaguar sniffed both options before confidently selecting the Brazil box. However, she briefly returned to inspect the Scotland choice, a moment experts on Poty say shouldn't be ignored.

"Maybe it indicates a tough game for us," BioParque biologist Caio de Souza Silva said.

"Maybe it's a win, but it could also be a more complicated match. Hopefully we don't concede a goal, but it may suggest a more physical game for Brazil."

Brazil co-leads Group C with Morocco at 4 points each, but is ahead on goal difference. Scotland has three points and could advance regardless of the result. Morocco's rival will be Haiti, which is yet to add points to its tally. (AP)

Argentina's Alvarez says he wants out of Atletico Madrid



Argentina forward Julian Alvarez wants out of Atletico Madrid. Alvarez spoke after Argentina's 2-0 win over Austria on Monday at the World Cup in Arlington, Texas.

"The best thing for everyone is a transfer," the 26-year-old player told ESPN. "I don't think it's the right time to talk about this, but I can't hide either. I have to be honest, and I spoke with people at the club, the ones I needed to talk to."

Not long after his comments were published in Spain, images of some Atletico fans burning the player's jersey were posted on social media.

Earlier this month, Real Madrid said Atletico rejected an offer of 150 million euros (\$ 171 million) for the 26-year-old Alvarez. The offer was part of the campaign promises made by Real Madrid President Florentino Perez ahead of his re-election.

Barcelona is also reportedly interested in signing the talented Argentina forward.

Atletico has said it does not intend to negotiate. Spanish media reported that there was a release clause for Alvarez worth 500 million euros (\$571 million). (AP)

Messi becomes top scorer in World Cup history

STEPHEN HAWKINS
■ Arlington (Texas)

Scoring goals and breaking records is what Lionel Messi does, and he is already doing that again in his sixth World Cup.

The Argentina captain now has the World Cup scoring record all to himself after another standout performance, one that began with frustration after missing a penalty kick and ended in pure elation with another victory.

Messi, who many consider the greatest player of all time, scored both goals in his team's 2-0 victory over Austria on Monday. That gave him 18, six days after his first-ever hat trick in the tournament had matched Germany striker Miroslav Klose's previous record of 16 World Cup goals. "Beyond anything I'm so happy for the win," Messi said. "It was huge, tough and difficult. It would allow us to be relaxed to what's ahead. All matches in this World Cup are very even, very intense. I'm enjoying this moment and craving to enjoy with my teammates."

The first goal against Austria came in the 38th minute and two days before his 39th birthday, and amid the concern of an ailing father back at home. It was the sixth consecutive World Cup game in which Messi has scored — joining France striker Just



MESSI SCORED BOTH GOALS IN TEAM'S VICTORY OVER AUSTRIA. "BEYOND ANYTHING I'M SO HAPPY FOR WIN," HE SAID

Fontaine and Brazil great Jairzinho as only players to do so.

That was about a half-hour after he missed a penalty kick with a chance to match the record.

"There were moments when I was really angry about missing the penalty, but I was able to make up

for it," said Messi, who has won a record eight Ballon d'Or awards as the best player in Europe.

Argentina advanced to the knockout round by winning its first two group games. Messi also scored all of his team's goals in a 3-0 win over

Haaland scores brace as Norway beat Senegal to reach World Cup Round of 32

RONALD BLUM
■ East Rutherford (New Jersey)

Erling Haaland scored twice to raise his World Cup goals total to four, as Norway advanced to the Round of 32 with a 3-2 win over Senegal on Monday night.

Marcus Pederson put the Vikings ahead in the 43rd minute after replacing an injured teammate, and Haaland kept up his incredible goals streak in the 48th and 58th minutes to build a 3-1 lead.

First he ran onto Martin Odegaard's pass and put a left-footed shot past the outstretched left hand of goalkeeper Edouard Mendy, capping an end-to-end counterattack for a 2-0 lead.

For his second goal, Haaland tunneled through the defence and 8 yards out raised his weaker right foot to volley in Patrick Berg's pass.

Haaland raised a hand to an ear to inspire the thousands of red clad Norway supporters behind the north goal who performed the Viking Row — chanting "Ro!" while mimicking oarsmen.

Haaland has 24 goals in his last 12 international games — scoring at least once in every match — and



59 goals in 52 international appearances.

The 25-year-old striker joined England's Harry Kane in 2018 as the only players in the last 50 years with two-goal games in their first two World Cup appearances.

He is second in the Golden Boot race, one behind Argentina's Lionel Messi and tied with France's Kylian

Mbappe. Haaland nearly got another in first-half stoppage time, hitting a post after Mendy lost control of the ball.

Ismaila Sarr scored in the 53rd minute and in the third minute of second-half stoppage time for the Lions of Teranga.

Making its first World Cup appearance since 1998, Norway (2-0) is assured of advancing from Group I along with France.

The Vikings need to beat Les Bleus on Friday for first place and what would appear to be an easier path in the knockout bracket.

While not eliminated, Senegal is 0-2 in a World Cup for the first time and needs a win over Iraq (0-2) to have any chance of advancing as a third-place team.

Pederson entered in the 13th minute for his World Cup debut after Julian Ryerson got hurt, and he put the Vikings ahead with the help of mistakes by Senegal captain Kalidou Koulibaly and Mendy. (AP)

Mbappe scores twice to lead France into knockout stage



DAN GELSTON ■ Philadelphia

Kylian Mbappe scored twice to move into a tie for second in career World Cup goals with 16, as France played through the tournament's first rain delay to beat Iraq 3-0 on Monday and advance to the knockout stage. Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele also scored for Les Bleus, giving fans, who were stuck on a rainy night in Philadelphia, a reason to cut loose.

Mbappe scored in the 14th and 54th minutes to cap a momentous and soggy 100th interna-

tional appearance for one of the best players in the world.

Mbappe had a chance at the hat trick on a late breakaway, but missed before he was subbed out at 90-minute mark. Mbappe's first goal gave France a 1-0 lead into halftime, when heavy rain and an incoming thunderstorm prompted a delay of just over two hours and forced grounds crew to squeeze water off swampy Kentucky grass field. (AP)

Algeria rallies past Jordan 2-1 for its first win at World Cup since 2014

JOSH DUBOW
■ Santa Clara (USA)

Algeria scored off two corner kicks in the second half to rally from an early deficit and defeat Jordan 2-1 to bolster its chances of advancing to the knockout round of World Cup.

Second-half substitute Nadhir Benbouali headed in a corner kick in the 69th minute and Amine Gouiri provided the game-winner in the 82nd to give Algeria its first win at the World Cup since 2014 on Monday night.

The Jordanians had taken the lead for the first time at



a World Cup on a first-half goal by Nizar Al Rashdan but couldn't withstand the continual pressure from Algeria in the second half.

This marked the first time Algeria had ever won a World Cup game after conceding the first goal. They had seven losses and two draws previ-

ously when that happened.

Algeria bounced back after a 3-0 to Argentina in its opening game and can finish second in Group J — and clinch a spot in knockout round — with a win on Saturday against Austria. (AP)



Win over Saudi Arabia would send Cape Verde to round of 32

TIM REYNOLDS
■ Miami Gardens (Florida)

Here's something that very few could have reasonably expected coming into this World Cup: Cape Verde controls its own destiny with one match left in group play.

That's right. With a win on Friday against Saudi Arabia, the tiny nation of about 500,000 people and about 15 million new Instagram followers will be headed to the round of 32. Even a draw might be — should be — enough to earn a spot in the knockout round.

The Blue Sharks were long shots entering the World Cup; some books had them



at no better than 12 percent to advance from the group stage. They're currently favored to move on.

"It's in our hands," defender Roberto Lopes said. "We have to go and take it."

A pair of draws - first against Spain to begin group play, then rallying for a 2-2 result against Uruguay on Sunday - has Cape Verde still searching for its first win in its initial World Cup appear-

ance. Still, the team is in an ideal position.

Spain leads Group H with four points. Uruguay and Cape Verde are next with two points each, while Saudi Arabia is last with one point. The top two teams from each group advance to the round of 32 along with the top eight third-place teams in the 12 groups.

A win over Saudi Arabia by Cape Verde would give it five points; it would then be mathematically certain to be no worse than second in the group. A draw would give the team three points; that, combined with a Spain win over Uruguay, would also assure a second-place finish in group play. (AP)

Priced out of World Cup games, Mexican fans take celebrations into their own hands

MEGAN JANETSKY ■ Mexico City

"GOOOOOOOOOOAL!"

The thunderous cry rings out over a crowd gathered in front of a television propped up on plastic tables and past a maze of vendors lining a bustling working-class neighbourhood in downtown Mexico City. It echoes over fans across the Latin American nation, who roar as they watch Mexico's national team win another match in the FIFA World Cup with eyes glued to screens set up in plazas, below highway underpasses and tucked away in taco stands.

Priced out of stadium tickets to the tournament their country is hosting alongside the US and Canada, many Mexicans are reclaiming the event and staging their own celebrations on the streets.

"Honestly, there's nothing like going

to the stadiums, but I prefer being here in the street. For me it's like watching the game from my living room," said Esmeralda Serrato, who watched a TV in the street with dozens of neighbors. "I feel the blood rushing through my veins saying This is the World Cup."

Ticket prices exclude most Mexican viewersWorld Cup festivities in Mexico have generated an almost incalculable buzz as hundreds of thousands of people gather in mass celebrations in host cities including Mexico City, Guadalajara and Monterrey following the country's two consecutive victories.

But the street parties also come after months of scrutiny as FIFA has faced searing criticism across the globe for soaring World Cup ticket prices. In Mexico, where the average worker



earns around \$433 a month and soccer is considered a sport that unites people across class, the gap between who can and cannot get into games is felt acutely.

That has fueled social tensions and left many Mexicans feeling as if "it's a party we weren't invited to," said Diego Merla, fiscal justice coordinator for Oxfam Mexico.

"The World Cup is built around the logic of squeezing as much value out of it as possible," Merla said. "It's about getting those who are willing and able to pay the absolute maximum. And that ends up excluding a lot of people."

Earlier this year, tickets went on sale at prices ranging from \$140 to \$8,680, but have since skyrocketed, with some tickets to the World Cup final costing around \$32,970.

In the wake of mounting criticisms, FIFA President Gianni Infantino has

defended high ticket prices as fitting the US market. "You cannot go to watch in the US a college game, not even speaking about a top professional game of a certain level, for less than \$300," Infantino said. "And this is World Cup."

Fans hold hometown celebrations For fans like Guillermo Ramirez, the solution was to take things into their own hands.

Ramirez, 49, is a native of Tepito, the working-class Mexico City neighborhood that is home to sprawling street markets packed with pirated World Cup jerseys. Here, soccer is a symbol of resistance and local identity in an area of the city most commonly associated with crime. Nestled in the heart of the dense markets is a soccer field named after Bernardo Manolete Hernandez, a renowned Mexican soccer player born in the neighborhood. (AP)

Sreeshankar, Kujur lead star cast at Inter-State Championships

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Bhubaneswar

Star long jumper Murali Sreeshankar, sprinter Animesh Kujur and quarter-miler Vishal TK would be among a host of track and field stars who would be vying for a spot in India's Asian Games squad by attaining the requisite marks at the National Inter-State Championships beginning on Wednesday.

Seasoned shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor and star 3000m steeple-chaser Parul Chaudhary — both gold medallists at the 2022 Asian Games — would also be in action during the five-day meet. Another Asian Games gold medallist, javelin thrower Annu Rani is also participating in the championships, though she has been struggling of late. Young high jumper Pooja Singh is also among the ones to watch out for at the meet.



The championship, being held at the Kalinga Stadium after a gap of three years, is the only selection trial for the Asian Games in Japan in September-October, according to the Athletics Federation of India (AFI).

Javelin throw superstar Neeraj

Chopra, who began his season in the Doha Diamond League last week, has been exempted from taking part in the championship as he continues to work on achieving top fitness.

Another top javelin thrower, Sachin Yadav, who finished fourth in the 2025

World Championships, is not in the field, apparently due to an injury.

Other stars missing the championships include sprinter Gurindervir Singh, who recently smashed the 100m national record with a sensational run of 10.09 seconds and Commonwealth

Games medal-winning 3000m steeple-chaser Avinash Sable. Gurindervir has opted out to focus on the upcoming Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, while Sable is not fully fit after he underwent an ACL surgery last year.

In the absence of Gurindervir, the fight for the fastest man of the championships could be among Kujur, Manikanta Hoblidhar, and Lalu Prasad Bhoi, among others. Kujur is also competing in the men's 200m event in which he holds the national record.

Women's 100m hurdle national record holder Jyothi Yarraji, who like Sable also underwent an ACL surgery last year, is fit now and she will hope to hit form and breach the Asian Games qualifying mark of 13.34 seconds in her season-opening event.

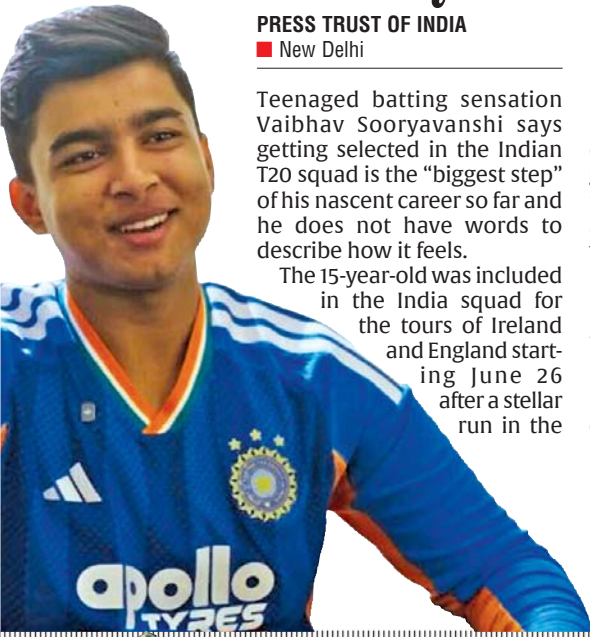
The 2018 Asian Games medallist quarter-miler Hima Das is also skipping

the championships, along with decathlete Tejaswin Shankar, who rewrote his own national record at the Federation Cup last month. The men's long jump and javelin throw, as well as the men's and women's 400m races are expected to be highly competitive events.

Jeswin Aldrin holds the long jump national record of 8.42m since 2023 but he has not crossed 8m mark for the last three years. The injury-prone 24-year-old jumped 7.73m at the Federation Cup last month and he would be hoping to improve his performance here.

Sreeshankar has put behind the disappointment of finishing a poor 14th in the 2025 World Championships and he has been in top form this season, hitting 8m-plus jumps in all the four events so far, including a gold-winning show of 8.08m in the Federation Cup. (PTI)

A dream is fulfilled and words can't explain it: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi on India selection



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Teenaged batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi says getting selected in the Indian T20 squad is the "biggest step" of his nascent career so far and he does not have words to describe how it feels.

The 15-year-old was included in the India squad for the tours of Ireland and England starting June 26 after a stellar run in the

IPL 2026, where he scored 776 runs for Rajasthan Royals at a strike-rate over 230.

"Words can't explain it. The reason I picked up a bat from day one and went to the cricket ground for practice, and today that dream is fulfilled," Sooryavanshi said in a brief video posted by BCCI on its social media handles.

"The biggest step in the journey was completed today. I truly cannot put this feeling into words," he added.

Sooryavanshi started his cricketing journey from the humble surroundings of Samastipur in Bihar and came to limelight in IPL 2025, scoring a marauding hundred against Gujarat Titans.

At 14 years and 32 days then, he remains the youngest centurion in T20 cricket with his 38-

ball 101 on April 28, 2025 against Gujarat.

Now, the left-hander's national debut might happen in Belfast against Ireland either on June 26 or 28. If he appears against either Ireland or England, Sooryavanshi could become the youngest ever international cricketer for India at 15, surpassing the great Sachin Tendulkar's record of 16 years and 205 days.

Sooryavanshi said he deeply cherishes the moment he unboxed his India T-shirt with his name imprinted on the back.

"I just felt it like a dream, the moment I saw that T-shirt. I couldn't stop smiling," he said.



Shedge replaces Nitish in India's squads for Ireland, England series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The promising Suryansh Shedge has replaced injured all-rounder Nitish Reddy in India's squads for the upcoming T20I series against Ireland and England, the BCCI said on Tuesday.

Earlier, India were dealt a blow as Reddy was ruled out of the white ball tour of UK with a quadriceps injury that he had sustained during the recent ODI series against Afghanistan. "The men's selection committee has named Suryansh Shedge as a replacement for Nitish Kumar Reddy in India's squads for the upcoming T20I series against Ireland and England," the BCCI said in a statement.

Reddy reported left quadri-



ceps discomfort after the third ODI against Afghanistan on June 20. Following a subsequent medical assessment, the BCCI medical team has recommended a period of rehabilitation.

tion, ruling him out of both T20I series.

Shedge earned the call-up following a string of impressive performances for India A in the recently concluded tri-series in Sri Lanka. Batting in the middle order, the 23-year-old scored 147 runs in five matches and also chipped in with the ball, bowling 23 overs across the tournament. He was also one of the standout performers for Mumbai in their victorious Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy campaign in 2024-25, scoring 131 runs at a strike rate of 251.92 in lower middle order.



Pant takes big pay cut to rejoin DC for ₹15 crore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Rishabh Pant took a massive pay cut of ₹12 crore after two underwhelming seasons as the Lucknow Super Giants' captain and Delhi Capitals wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav were involved in a high-profile trade off completed on Tuesday.

Pant returns to the Capitals for ₹15 crore. The LSG had acquired his services for a whopping ₹27 crore, highest-ever in the history of the league, in the mega auction ahead of IPL 2025.

Incidentally, LSG owner Sanjiv Goenka back in the day, had claimed that the deal with Pant will be a long-term one but only after two disappointing seasons, the LSG owners with tacit support from Australian heavy coaching staff (Justin Langer and Tom Moody) decided on releasing the flamboyant keeper-batter.

In an expected trade-off, left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav went from the Capitals to LSG at his existing fee of ₹13.50 crore.

Pant will now reconnect with the franchise for whom he had played 111 matches between 2016 and 2024, before leaving to take part in the auction.

He was also their skipper between 2021 and 2024, guiding them in 43 matches.

However, his stint with the LSG was well below par both in the leadership role as well as a wicket-keeper batter.

The Super Giants ended up at seventh on the IPL 2025 table with six wins and eight defeats, while IPL 2026 panned out to be even worse.



Varma warms up for UK T20I with 136 in TG20

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

India vice-captain Tilak Varma warmed up for the upcoming away T20I series against Ireland and England with an unbeaten 136 off 56 balls that propelled Medak Falcons to three-wicket win over Warangal Warriors in TG20 in Hyderabad.

Chasing a mammoth 259, Tilak got off the blocks quickly to ensure that the Falcons kept up



with the required run rate as they scored fifty in fourth over. Tilak registered his fifty in 22 balls to help his side past the

stitched a 58-run partnership with Vikram to keep Falcons alive. Vikram (27) fell in the penultimate over with 20 runs needed from 12 balls.

But Tilak, who hammered 14 fours and eight sixes, stood tall to take his side home.

Earlier, promising Hyderabad batter and Warriors captain Aman Rao Perala set the tone for the high-scoring contest with his blazing 32-ball century, scoring 142 in 48 balls to help his side post a daunting target of 259.

Mother sold her jewellery to buy me cricket kit, want to give something back'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Manchester

Despite becoming a regular member of the Indian women's cricket team, pacer Kranti Gaud has not forgotten her roots and the sacrifices that her parents made to support her career and she wants to repay their faith by excelling at the ongoing T20 World Cup here.

Gaud, who hails from a small village in Madhya Pradesh, recollected how her mother sold jewellery to buy her cricket kit.

"If your family supports you, then what others say doesn't matter because those outsiders are not supporting you anyway. I am grateful to my family for standing by me through every step because there were a lot of problems. There was always a shortage of money," Gaud told JioStar.



Pacer Kranti Gaud

Now, Gaud wants to make her family proud by performing well for India.

"My mother sold her jewellery to buy me a proper cricket kit. That was a huge sacrifice. My family was doing so much for me, and that made me feel responsible. I wanted to give something back to them. I wanted to make their sacrifice count."

Arjan Singh Memorial Hockey event: IAF beat Army Southern Command



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jallahalli (Karnataka)

Indian Air Force beat Indian Army (Southern Command) 2-0 in the opening match of the 7th edition of Marshal of the Air Force Arjan Singh Memorial Hockey Tournament-2026, organised by Air Force Sports Control Board.

Agniveer Vinayak Santosh Hande was declared as Man of the Match. A total of 16 Teams will be participating in this tournament. The opening ceremony was attended by Air Marshal S Sivakumar, VSM, Air Officer-in-Charge Administration (AOA), who declared the tournament open. The Chief Guest presented a cheque of ₹25,000 to Hande. Speaking on the occasion, Air Marshal Sivakumar said, "We are delighted to be back with the Marshal of the Arjan Singh Memorial Hockey Tournament which is the most prestigious tournament in the country."

Court upholds AITA General Body's authority in reforms



AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has reaffirmed the primacy of the All India Tennis Association's (AITA) General Body in deciding amendments to its constitution, directing that proposed changes be placed before the federation's members for clause-by-clause consideration and voting.

A Division Bench of Justices Tejas Karia and Madhu Jain passed the interim order while hearing cross appeals filed by the AITA and former Davis Cup player Somdev Devvarman against an April 27 judgment of a single judge.

Batting order flexibility is key in white ball cricket: Former all-rounder Vijay Shankar

SUMAN RAY ■ Chennai

Batting-order flexibility has become a key factor in modern white-ball cricket, and former India all-rounder Vijay Shankar believes players who can seamlessly adapt to different roles are increasingly valuable in a format driven by situational demands.

Having batted everywhere from Number 3 to Number 8 for India and in the IPL, Vijay said the game's evolution has enhanced the importance of genuine all-rounders, who can contribute with both bat and ball while adjusting to the team's requirements. He also stressed that aspiring all-rounders must embrace the demands of the role rather than complain about workload and fitness challenges.

"We as all-rounders can't blame the workload. We became all-rounders after dealing with double workloads from the beginning. So



fast-bowling all-rounders can't blame any extra workload for their injuries or lack of fitness," Vijay, who recently retired from Indian domestic cricket said during an interaction.

For Vijay, all-rounders are genuine game-changers and also ones who are the most flexible in any set up because of their multiple skills. "The beauty of all-rounder is, you know, you bat anywhere and every-

where. So, the thing I had was that I was batting everywhere. I was batting up the order and at times down the order. "Whatever the team needs, I was very flexible. That was like plus and minus for me. Because individually, I was not able to score bigger runs since I was floating up and down," Vijay lamented about his brief international career in which he played 12 ODIs and 9 T20Is for the national team. (PTI)

Sports Ministry invites applications for National Sports Board positions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Sports Ministry on Tuesday invited applications for the post of Chairperson and two members in the National Sports Board, which will act as the central authority for granting recognition to sports bodies and ensuring their compliance with governance, and financial standards mandated by the sports law passed last year.

The appointment in the National Sports Board will be made on the recommendations of a Search-cum-Selection Committee headed by cabinet secretary TV Somanathan.

Olympic bronze-



winning former shooter Gagan Narang and weightlifting great N Kunjarani Devi are also in the five-member committee. The other members are: Sports Secretary Hari Ranjan Rao, and Indian Olympic Association's (IOA) Executive Council member Lt General (Retd) Harpal Singh.